

BOOK THREE
DEMONS



Devil
IN THE **WATERS**

KT MORRISON

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About the Author

KT Morrison writes stories about women who fall in love with sexy men who aren't their husband, and loving relationships that go too far—couples who open a mysterious door, then struggle to get it closed as trouble pushes through the threshold.

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All characters are over the age of eighteen.

DEMONS

A Devil In The Waters Novella

Book 3

40,000 words

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Introduction

A few months ago I began a Patreon. It's a website where creators can garner support from their fans who wish to be patrons.

The aim of my Patreon is to help support the quicker finishing of series' I have still left hanging, and in return I offer a frequent-update series appearing first on Patreon where all the patrons analyze and debate every character's actions and motivations—it's grown to a great and active little community . . .

for more info:

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I

Monday, August 3

Cranes

All morning he'd been in a bad mood he couldn't shake.

Quarter to eleven now and he was on break finally, coming out of the cafeteria line at Swanson with a coffee and a croissant, looking to find Steve who'd got out into the seating area ahead of him.

The thing between him and Kimmy right now wasn't what you would call a fight. That's because he wasn't putting up any obstacles to his wife working for Devlin. It was like he was afraid of a fight, or at least actively avoiding one. If he were to express what he wanted, he was afraid Kimmy would reject his objection. Deep down the truth was simple. He did not want Kimmy to work for Devlin. Simple. He could say to his wife: "Kimmy, it's a bad idea." And where would that leave him? She would ask why it's a bad idea and he would express his doubts about . . . about what? The state of their marriage? What would he say to her? I'm afraid you'll cheat on me . . . If you haven't already. And Kimmy (who hadn't cheated on him, nor would she) would be offended. Or worse: Mad. And wouldn't she have that right?

He tried to picture it like he had a new and attractive female co-worker with a loose and over-sexed reputation and this imaginary girl was all over him, and Kimmy objected to his proximity to her. Would that make him mad? . . . Hard to say. Proud, maybe. Like riled that Kimmy valued him so much to worry. But what if she flat out forbade it? He could see scenarios where she became unreasonable that might make him angry. He could see it, could hear himself saying, "So, what?—you want me to give up the chance at all this money because you don't trust me? . . ." If he could picture himself mad, then he could also understand how he might sound irrational to Kimmy if he expressed how he didn't want her to work for Devlin Stone.

Steve sat at their usual table by the window, and Josh worked his way between the seating to get there.

Here's the thing: the texts from Devlin had been deleted from his phone. The contact deleted as well. So now he couldn't even go back over them to remind himself how real the taunting had been. And the more time passed after Tiffany's post-reunion cottage party, the more unreal that interaction with Devlin in the tent seemed. Would a grown man come into his tent and show off his penis? Ask him to put his hand on it? It didn't even sound right.

He'd had so much to drink at Tiffany's party that even in the light of the following day, surmising the veracity of his dreamy memory had been tainted by alcohol. How trustworthy was his interpretation of that dream? Since the party, there'd been no contact with Devlin. Not for sure, at least. No direct taunts, nothing. And in retrospect, he couldn't even remember talking to the guy. Dream Devlin'd said they talked at the picnic table. Had they? And if dream Devlin was only a dream, had he ever talked to the guy at all? Could parts of this be fabrication—his fearful mind filling in drunken memory gaps with horrible little gems of hurt? . . . Another particularly shiny red gem: When he couldn't get erect, all he'd had to do was think of Devlin's big hard bulge dry-humping Kimmy and his own penis went off like a rocket. How much of this was all in his head?

It helped to analyze his situation by taking the pile of components, and arranging them into two boxes. True and Unsure. Devlin in the tent was unsure. Devlin's taunting texts were unsure. Close to True but proof would remain in Devlin's mouth. It would go into the True box when he heard directly from Devlin: "Yes, Josh, I sent you those texts." And if Devlin didn't send them? Who knows—maybe Amy. . . . It was something to consider. In the True box was that Devlin had held down his wife and tried to kiss her. Kimmy'd said Devlin was hard.

And that there was the real sticking point. That was the only leverage he could use against Kimmy to question why she'd decide to go work as a lawyer in-house at Devlin's import-export business. But the more-than-valid point had already been countered by a whopping dollar sign. Yeah, the guy tried to hump me, Josh, but he offered me a great-paying job.

The fact that Kimmy'd never said, "You know you can trust me," could go either way. "I don't even have to say it," is what that could mean (which was where his head was at), but sometimes at night he'd wonder if maybe his wife knew not to make promises she couldn't keep. Like Kimmy wouldn't say "Trust me," because even she was afraid she couldn't honor that.

His tray of food went down hard on the cafeteria table, making Steve jump. "Jesus, take it easy." Steve scowled, thumb and finger still in his mouth where he'd just tucked in the heel of his tuna bagel.

Josh apologized, dropped his weight down on the chair and scooted nearer the table. Steve eyed him.

"You guys aren't fighting, are you?"

"Me and Kimmy? No, we're not fighting," he said. The thing between them wasn't a fight . . . but it could be called a disturbance. "We're not fighting at all." But maybe they should. Maybe he should have a sit-down head-to-head and lay it all on the table. I don't like Devlin at all, not one bit, and you know it, and while I trust you . . . I don't trust him. Shit, when he put it that way it didn't sound so bad at all. Little late now though, isn't it, Josh? I mean, she's already working for him.

Steve said, "And it's Monday. Today's Kimmy's big day."

"It is," Josh said, fists on either side of his tray, the curve of his croissant like a smug smile on a plate.



Tami was in her mid-twenties, an effusive and endearing girl with Indian parents. And her new secretary. Tami currently appeared busy but

frequently side-glanced into the office to see what Kimmy was up to. She was being assessed.

Her new office faced south on the tenth floor of the P&G Building, Yonge and Sheppard, North Toronto. A furnished but otherwise empty space, about ten-by-fifteen, that she was currently setting up with artwork bought using an allowance from Devlin. Or at least deciding where it should go. She asked for Tami's help.

Sunlight streamed through the window wall, falling across the space where another picture had once hung, the gray-painted wall sun-faded but for a darker square. Tami bustled, glad to be of help and not hanging around out front spying, taking up the end of a framed print depicting a traditional Chinese painted landscape, a pine branch and two stylized long-necked cranes in the foreground.

They both regarded the square of darker paint and Kimmy said, "What was up here before?"

"A landscape, like, a Group Of Seven, I think."

Kimmy said, "Who had the office before me?"

"Mel. Mel Wilson. The guy who you replaced."

Replaced? She'd thought she was added on. Did Devlin remove a lawyer to make room for her?

"I think your picture's going to cover the square," Tami said hopefully as the two women hoisted it up in place, getting the braided cable to hug the hook already in the wall.

"Let's hope so," Kimmy said, both of them now carefully removing their hands, seeing if the big picture would stay up. It did.

They stepped back to admire, gauge levelness, both of them with hands on hips. Tami wore a dark suit jacket and skirt with a satiny wine-colored blouse. Kimmy's suit was also black, hers with pants that came to a high

waist, pointed toes of her shoes under the hem like two patent leather daggers. It was a treat she'd purchased for herself in congratulations on her new job. She had suits she wore at Immigration, but this one was far nicer. It felt nicer, it looked nicer. She loved how it fit. The shaggy cut of her hair was pulled back, all business, the dullness chased away with gleaming product, bangs tidied and combed, the remaining length collected in a tight and neat bun. No makeup except for a line of black around her eyes and a shimmering lipstick in a color not unlike the natural dusky rose of her own lips.

"It's beautiful," Tami said. "Where did you get it?"

"Pacific Mall. My dad picked it out."

"Aw, that's nice," Tami said. "He live in Markham?"

"He does now. We grew up in Kingston."

Tami nodded, her lips pursed but wriggling; a question forming there but her mind weighing whether it might be appropriate. "I . . . heard you knew Mr. Stone Junior from before."

"Yes. We're both from the suburbs outside Kingston. We went to school together."

"U of T?"

"No," Kimmy laughed. "High school."

"Oh, really?" Tami laughed honestly and touched a hand to her chest.

"We go way back," Kimmy said. Then out of the blue: "My husband, too. We both went to high school with Devlin. Mr. Stone, I mean. Junior." She held up her left hand, waggled her fingers to show off her wedding ring. Like she had to prove it. Or was defensive.

It only made sense. It took two seconds to figure out this conclave would be a den of whispered gossip. Even the way Tami had presented the query: I heard that . . . It would be best to establish a professional veneer right from

the get-go and not let visible chumminess with Devlin prompt all sorts of office gossip and rumors.

The administration, legal, management, and accounting offices of Stone Custom Brokerage LLC took up an eighth of the tenth floor of the P&G. There was an office in Kingston (it had been the only office up till ten years ago, now it was a satellite) a shipping warehouse in Kingston and another one in Toronto, down on the docks in the east end. Here at the P&G there were four secretaries, all young women in their twenties; two middle-aged guys in accounting, Joseph and Ronald; two managers who she hadn't met yet; three middle-aged women, Anna, Veronica, and Gail, who all performed HR duties and similar, Veronica and Gail were Chinese but weren't lawyers. A lot of possible vectors for the spreading of rumors involving the new woman who was already familiar with their handsome alpha male boss. There was sure to already be a vast anthology of rumors, anecdotes, and salacious stories surrounding Devlin Stone around Stone Custom Brokerage. It would take effort to be distant from them.

It would be easy to get embroiled in gossip. Either as the subject or source. Tami would find value in her new boss through suggested inter-office scandal or by digging the mine of Devlin's past to entertain her cohorts. A professional barrier needed to be erected if she wanted to ensure that her relationship with her boss wasn't fodder.

Tami was already on a roll. "Your husband, is he one of Devlin's buddies?"

"No, it's not like that. We all just grew up in the same neighborhood." Closed off the conversation, then turned, headed to her desk. "Dial my father for me, will you—his number's in the list of contacts I gave you."

With a "Yes, Mrs. Chang," Tami returned to her desk out front, situated between Kimmy's office and the accountants'. By the time Kimmy'd sat down in her leather office chair, her phone was lit with an active line.

"Hey, Pop," she said into the receiver.

"Ah, my Kimmy, how are you? Big day today."

“You know it. Hey, I got your picture hung on my wall and it’s perfect.”

“I hope you like it.”

She said she did, then filled him in on how it’d been going. Told him about the three days of training she’d attended in Kingston, getting to know how Devlin’s brokerage worked, and the three-day conference she went to on her own dime, freshening up her corporate law knowledge.

“And how’s Josh? He good?”

“He sure is, Pop,” she told him. Though saying there wasn’t disgruntlement would be a lie. Josh currently boogie-boarded on a wave of resentment, arms out, struggling for balance, not saying a word to her about how much he didn’t like her taking the job. But her husband was smart as well as sweet. He knew what it could mean for their future. And taking the job wasn’t just for her and what she needed. It was for him too. She’d vowed to make that known to him.

“Come and have dinner,” her dad said, “you and Josh, before the summer’s over . . .”

“Sure thing, Pop. When do you want to . . .”

Coming in from the elevators, Devlin appeared in the lobby, Tami jumping up now to greet him. Dark suit, white shirt, indigo tie, he had his sunglasses up in his hairline, and held at his chest was a bouquet of flowers in a silvery foil wrap. Shoot.

“Hey, Pop? . . . My boss is coming, can I call you later?”

Her dad was apologizing even though it was she who’d called him, and she was apologizing too, then they whispered quiet goodbyes. Out in the lobby Devlin engaged Tami, their body language making her think they were talking about her.

Phone hung up now, she rose, nodded and waved to Devlin, putting her hands in her pockets, coming around the desk as Tami ushered Devlin into

her office. She closed the door behind her, leaving them alone but completely visible behind the floor to ceiling glass barrier.

“What’s this?” she said, good-natured but perturbed, nodding her chin at the flowers he held.

“Welcome to Stone Brokerage, Mrs. Chang.” He smiled to one side, light picking up the color in his eyes, looking devilish.

She said, “I still can’t believe you convinced me to put my maiden name on my card.”

“It’s for the best and you know it,” he said, bypassing her now, moving to the side table under her newly hung picture and setting down the flowers then beginning to arrange them.

“Thanks for the flowers, but, really . . .?”

Still arranging, he said, “What’s wrong with flowers?”

“I don’t know . . .” What was wrong?—she couldn’t tell. It seemed . . . intimate. Something a man gave a woman who he had an interest in. “It seems . . .”

Devlin crossed his arms, eyed her, enjoying himself, the smile giving that away. “Worried about the hen house?” he cocked his head out toward Tami who looked like she was busy but could also be keeping them in her periphery.

“You don’t worry about that?”

“Nothing I can do to do to stop them from obsessing where I put my cock.”

She scoffed, chuckled, rubbed the back of her neck. “You can be glib. Don’t hold back.”

He laughed, and she didn’t like them looking too chummy; it was like they were on a stage or in a TV set the way they were on display for an audience.

Devlin said, “Let the hens cluck, Kimmy.”

“Do me a favor?”

“What’s that?” Smiling, smug, dashing.

“Just don’t . . . you know, not here.”

“Kimmy,” he said, up off the table where he’d been leaning, moving around the office and looking out toward sunny downtown. “Did you think I was going to lay you out on the desk and ravish you?”

“No . . . We just haven’t talked. I’ve hardly seen you.”

“Afraid I’ve lost interest?” His eyes traveled down her body then back up again, enjoying the teasing.

“I hope so,” she said, but with the words out in the air now she was pretty sure she hoped he was still interested. It had been three weeks since they’d fooled around in his car, and there’d been nothing untoward since then. Devlin’d been professional. Her life here would be easier if he lost interest, but maybe she enjoyed some of the attention.

Devlin said, “Would it hurt your feelings?”

She sighed, crossed her arms tighter and didn’t look away—kept her eyes on his. “It would be a relief.”

“I can keep my hands off you, if you’re concerned I might try to tear your pants down in front of all your new co-workers and try to get it inside you again. I have the occasional bout of self-control.”

“The flowers make me nervous,” she said, turning and touching the white petals of a carnation in his bouquet.

“If I were you, I’d worry about the color in your cheeks since I came in.”

She frowned, touched knuckles to a cheek, looking for heat. “I’m not blushing.”

“Sure you’re not.” He got closer but kept some distance between them.
“You look beautiful, by the way. This suit is killing me.”

“It’s new.”

“You have an incredible figure. All legs . . . and that beautiful face. And that brain. I think I’m getting lucky both ways.”

“We should have rules,” she said.

“We should,” he said, nodding. “Makes it really hot when we break them.”

“This is the relentless Devlin I anticipated.”

“You got what you expected. I hope I get what I paid for.”

“Why don’t we have lunch?”

“You just can’t wait, can you?”

She said, “We can talk about those rules.”

“Can’t, Kimmy. Sorry. Meetings all afternoon then I’m back in Kingston for the night.”

She gave him no reaction, hid a small seeping amount of disappointment.

He said, “But welcome to your new office.” Now he came closer, moved near so she could smell his musky cologne, leaned past her to handle his own flowers he’d gifted. She looked at the soft petals held in his large masculine hand, his thumb caressing, the curled pink edge of a petal flipping under the pad of his thumb—and thought wondrously of her own labia under his touch . . .

If she hadn’t blushed before, now she could feel it. The tops of her ears burned.

He continued: “I hope you and I will do wonderful things here. We’ll have lunch together, you can bet on it. I know I’ll be seeing you a lot.” He

chuckled like he had a window seat on that awful and salacious thought she'd just had, then straightened and passed her by.

At the door, he paused. She turned, saw him standing in the gap of her open office door, Tami at her desk behind him.

“Maybe tomorrow. Busy schedule, but we should some fit some time in. Good seeing you . . .” Then tilting his head aside to regard Tami, he added: “Say hi to Josh for me.”

Then he was gone, and she stood dumb for a moment, parsing how what he'd said may be interpreted by her secretary then worrying how it would appear if Tami were to turn and catch her standing like this in Devlin's wake, caught in an obvious reverie . . . She returned to her desk, sat and spun away. In her iPhone's camera she studied her own face, turning side to side, seeing a blush under her faint freckles . . .

Damn it.

Table For Four

At a table for four situated in the centre of the Martinique's dining floor, Josh sat with Meyer and Sophie waiting for their fourth diner to arrive who swore she wouldn't be late, but was. Above their head hung an upside down birdcage interwoven with fake ivy, but it was the re-purposed yellow traffic stoplight with a flashing green light that had Sophie's attention, his little niece laughing and pointing at it occasionally but without saying her reasons for amusement, expecting her dad and uncle to just know exactly what it was so dazzling.

The Martinique was a family restaurant, kid friendly, every table filled with families and a handful of kids; the place was loud but clean and air-conditioned, dim and nicely decorated, sun bright out in the strip mall's parking lot, early evening sun still bright enough to send up sparks off chrome and clean windshields. They were waiting for Kimmy but had ordered appetizers when she said she might be a little late (twenty minutes ago), the basket of mozzarella sticks reduced to crumbs and grease stains on the checkerboard wax paper. He was on his second Diet Coke, Meyer on a second iced tea, Sophie with a glass of water after her milk was done.

Only one thing on Josh's mind right now, and he passed that thing to Meyer under the table so Sophie wouldn't see, looking to get a second opinion. Meyer took it, frowning at him, not understanding.

Josh whispered. "Her card. Look at it."

Still frowning, not understanding the need for spy craft, Meyer read the card. "What . . .?"

"Look at it again."

His cousin's frown deepened and he re-read Kimmy's business card, still not seeing it. Meyer'd known Kimmy for years before they were married, so it wasn't obvious.

Josh hissed, "Jesus, Meyer, read it slow—"

Meyer got it now, head nodding, eyes widening. Then the brow went down again, this time lowered with concern. "Chang?" He gave Josh a scrunched what-the-fuck? face.

Sophie was bored and attentive, watching them, saying, "What is it?"

Meyer said, "Daddy stuff, Soph," then to Josh, "Why? Like why would she . . ."

"Her boss wants her to have a Chinese name so his Chinese clients will feel at ease, I guess . . ."

Meyer passed the card back, going under the table like he'd done. "Feels . . . I don't know, kind of—" he leaned closer and whispered "—racist."

"I don't think it is," Josh said, looking down in his lap where he held Kimmy Waters's new business card. Kimmy Chang, Stone Brokerage LLC, and underneath: Attorney At Law. But he wished he could convince Kimmy it was—just as a way to reel this thing back because it was feeling like he was losing control. Why had he agreed to it with all that was going on behind the scenes? Why would he risk his marriage? Up front, he knew he would never stand in his wife's way of anything—he wasn't that kind of man—but on the back burner was something he feared: a dark curiosity that tickled him when he thought of Devlin and his wife. There was no truth to Devlin's claims he'd asked for the man to fuck her (there was just no way), but he couldn't deny that sinking feeling he liked low in his belly when he felt unsure of his wife and imagined a secret desire she might have for the man who made his youth unbearable.

A flash of white light raced back and forth across the restaurant and the faces of the diners across from him as the front door opened, sunlight reflected from its glass inset. Kimmy had arrived, his wife coming into the

restaurant in a rush, eyes scanning the patrons quickly, pinpointing where he sat and heading their way. She was at the table before he had a chance to rise, and he watched as Meyer looked up and didn't recognize her. It was a seconds-long moment his cousin stared quizzically at the woman he'd known about as long as Josh had. Then he shook his head and laughed, and his mouth fell open. He half rose from his chair saying, "Kimmy, I didn't even recognize you, I was looking at you thinking who's this and why's she at our table? . . . Look at you, the suit and everything—and your hair . . ."

"Yeah, yeah," Kimmy said, waving Meyer off, moving widdershins around the table behind Sophie who was wide-eyed, head oscillating around to follow her favorite auntie as Kimmy came to the chair next to Josh. She slung her purse over the seat back, sat, then scooted forward. She leaned, and he leaned to meet her. They kissed. Then Kimmy was laughing, seeing Sophie staring incredulously. "What is it, Pumpkin—don't you recognize me, either?"

"Look at your hair," Sophie whispered.

Kimmy leaned forward, tilting her head down, and Sophie patted the top of Kimmy's head, her little hands moving over the rounded shape of Kimmy's bun. Then she batted at her combed bangs. "Look at your hair," Sophie whispered again.

Kimmy sat up. "Do you like it?"

"You're so pretty."

Kimmy made an affected expression (her niece's words warming her), and tucked her chin down then held out her hands to Sophie saying, "Come sit in my lap for a minute. Come see me."

As Sophie got out of her chair to climb up in Kimmy's lap, Kimmy said to Meyer, "Did you guys order yet? Sorry, I'm late, it's bumper-to-bumper all the way out of the city."

"Get used to it," Meyer said. "Josh says you stole his car."

“We bought a new one. We’re up to two cars again, but Josh gave me his for a week before we pick up the new one. Thanks for picking him up.”

“No prob. We didn’t order. We just had some mozzarella sticks.”

Kimmy made a face because she didn’t like cheese sticks, and Sophie got comfortable in Kimmy’s lap saying, “I like cheese sticks.”

Kimmy said, “Well I hope they didn’t eat them all on you.”

“I got some,” Sophie sang for Kimmy, putting on the cute act and still admiring her aunt’s hair.

Kimmy kissed Sophie’s forehead, then asked her, “Would you undo my hair for me?”

Sophie’s expression went to gleeful, and Kimmy leaned her ear toward Sophie who began trying to figure out how to get Kimmy’s bun to come apart. Her face was to him, and as Sophie worked the bun apart his wife made quiet but pained faces at him.

He said, “How was your first day?”

“Good,” she said, wincing, head jerking as Sophie tugged.

And like a dick, he went right to it. “How’s your buddy Devlin?”

She made an irritated sound but hid any chagrin from her expression. It should have been a sound expressed over Devlin, but it sounded like his question was what bothered her. She said, “I hardly saw him. He was in for a few minutes.”

There were terrible words on his tongue, but he kept them at bay. I’m sure you were disappointed . . . The words of the disgruntled, passive-aggressive, and resentful. If he didn’t keep himself in check, he could put up a barrier between them before even realizing it.

He said nothing. Kimmy closed her eyes. Sophie saved the day. “Who’s the devil in?”

“Creepy, Soph,” Meyer said.

Josh said, “You don’t want to know,” made devil horns with wiggling index fingers held up at his temples and loomed nearer his niece who hid behind the mane of Kimmy’s untied hair.

Sophie cupped a hand to Kimmy’s ear and whispered. Kimmy nodded, then looked his way. She said, “Sophie thinks you guys were talking about me.”

Josh said, “When?”

Meyer laughed, said, “Oh yeah, we were definitely talking about you.”

Kimmy side-eyed Josh.

“Only good things,” Josh said.

Kimmy said to Sophie, “What do you think—were they saying good things?”

“Yes. Something about racing.”

Kimmy showed Soph a perplexed face. “That’s all you’ve got for me?”

Sophie shrugged, then smiled.

“Well, thanks for looking out for me, Sophie.”

Kimmy looked his way, but instead of any irritation Kimmy only showed him warmth and affection. With Soph braced in a hugging arm, she leaned toward him again and he leaned closer. She gave him a long sighing kiss against his cheek.

The touch of her lips healed whatever irritable angst scratched at his heart. Her lips slipped away, and she met his eyes. Then she chuckled and wiped at his cheek where she must have left a mark with her lipstick. Sophie giggled. Kimmy looked at her point blank. Put a lipstick mark on Sophie’s forehead while Sophie squealed.

II

Wednesday, August 5

Jourlet

Back in the Mercedes, Devlin asked her: “Whatever happened with your baskets?”

The cloudless sky beyond the windshield was a brilliant blue, gulls swooping above the geometric anti-arcology of multi-colored cargo containers stacked all around them in streets and narrows, tall as apartment buildings. The Mercedes sat in the cool blue shade of the enormous Jourlet Maersk, a Triple-E container ship coming in from Africa.

She said, “That’s what you wanted to ask me?”

They’d just come from a congenial and friendly meeting with Eddie Wu and a woman who was his lawyer and translator. Devlin’d wanted her to study Eddie, assess whether the translator was accurate and to look for what Eddie’s intent may be.

“Alright, go ahead,” Devlin said. “What do you think?”

She said, “The translator was accurate, in my opinion.”

“And what about Eddie’s intent?”

“The terms are reasonable.”

Devlin nodded. “For him or for me?”

“I don’t know. It’s a middle ground . . . beneficial for both of you.” She frowned, contemplating. “Tell me what you want.”

“My lawyer, naked in bed, begging me for round two.”

She chuckled—she’d been wondering when this Devlin would make an appearance. He’d been well-behaved all morning. She said, “Very clever,” rubbed her neck, looking up at the Jourlet, watching then as Eddie and his lawyer pulled away in his bright red Audi, on to their next appointment, looking for someone with well-greased connections to move braided steel from northern Ontario back to China. “I don’t think he’s trying to fuck you.”

Now Devlin chuckled, his head rolling her way. They looked at each other. He said, “Very clever.”

“Two can play at that game,” she said.

He kept her gaze and didn’t look away.

At last he said, “What do you say we meet up one night this week.”

“For work?”

He smiled warmly, eyes narrow and devilish. “You know what I mean.”

She sighed, rubbed her neck again. “I’m not sure, Devlin.”

He made a disappointed sound. “Couple of weeks apart and you’ve forgotten about me.”

“It’s not that.”

He raised his eyebrows like he was intrigued. “What is it then?”

She looked up at the gulls, let out a long exhausted sigh. “You asked about the baskets . . . I finished all my orders, completed them. The Katt Basket shop is closed. Josh helped me. Took days of his own time, two whole weekends with his sleeves rolled up—you should see his hands. They’re all scratched up.”

“Josh is a nice guy. I know Josh is a nice guy.”

She stared out the window, deliberating. “He really is. I don’t . . . think I can do that. Would you be mad?”

Devlin said, “Mad, no. Heartbroken.”

In her periphery, she could see him clutch a hand to his chest.

She rolled her eyes saying, “Oh, come on.”

“Are you saying no?”

She shrugged, shook her head. “I don’t know what I’m saying.”

Devlin nodded, hand smoothing his tie. “I took too long.”

She said, “Maybe you did.”

Devlin sighed, touched the Merc’s start button, big engine roaring to life. “Well, we could have been good.”

With the car brought to life, it was like their conversation was over and she didn’t think it was. Devlin was going to move on without her and that was for the best, but she couldn’t escape a cold sinking feeling, like being left behind. She said, “I’m not saying no.” Then hated that she said it, hugging her arms, looking to get her seatbelt.

Devlin shut off the car, the cabin going quiet again. He said, “Take a walk with me.”



The erection was unexpected and sudden. At his desk after lunch, planning a team meeting for the next morning, making notes, his mind wandered . . . and then . . .? Strange and dirty possibilities wavered before him like passing street signs in a dense fog.

What was Kimmy doing right now? Two in the afternoon, working for Devlin . . . what was her day like? The horrors of misinterpretation and betrayal stabbed out of the brume.

You're wrong about Kimmy. She only took the job to be close to Devlin. She wants him. She wants to cheat, but she's scared.

Then a clear image of his beloved Kimmy on her back on her desk, all the items cleared off in one swipe, and between her legs Devlin loomed, his mouth sucking on hers, only she's pulling away, gasping for breath, squeaking in pain as Devlin pushes his huge cock inside her—her nails tear his back . . . and then he's at home, Kimmy's in the kitchen like nothing happened, he's sitting on the couch and the taunting texts return, a message from Devlin saying Kimmy was too tight and he'd have to work her in, the only way it was possible to fuck her, Joshy, old Double-A, was how fucking wet your wife's pussy gets for me . . .

Two in the afternoon, plenty of work to do, and he's sitting at his desk now with a full and throbbing erection straining at the fly of his suit pants. Thoughts of his wife with Devlin were inescapable, and his cock ached with need. Hard as steel, straight and upright he palmed it hoping to ease the ache.

He muttered, "What the hell . . .?" rising up, hunched over then creeping to his office door and closing it.

When he returned to his chair, he leaned back with fingers laced behind his head, staring up at the florescent lights. He peeked down, looked at his bulge and pondered. Why in the middle of the day would this happen to him? Just the mere thought of Kimmy with Devlin was arousing him, and that truth was frightening. Because there was nothing else that had prompted it other than thinking of Kimmy and Devlin. Just like Devlin had said in the tent. And what if, as he suspected, the thing in the tent never even really happened? You're going to have to address this . . . If Devlin didn't appear in the tent—and it was crazy to believe he did—that meant the whole scenario was prompted from within your own mind, Josh. You were the one who made the story up. But was it horror? Was it a nightmare? What was it in him that would conjure such a devilish scenario as his high

school bully taking advantage of his wife, and his wife letting it happen?
Did it arouse him?

“What do you think?” he said to his empty office, sitting more upright, palming the humped belly of the erection in his pants. There’s your proof.

Then he was moving before thinking, bringing over his phone, bypassing texting, straight to dialing. The phone rang and rang and his heart sank, squeezing his eyes shut at the horrible but lubricious image of Kimmy now with her hands on the bathroom sink of Devlin’s office, squeaking and gasping as Devlin with his suit pants around his ankles pummeled her hard from behind, Kimmy’s thighs shaking—

“Hello?” Kimmy sounding upbeat and outside, definitely not engaged in sex from behind with Devlin in a bathroom.

“Where are you?” There was the sound of heavy equipment, banging and clanging.

“What’s going on, Josh?”

“Just thinking of you and I wanted to call you—” and now he felt stupid, coming up with a reason to call, saying, “—make plans with you for tonight . . .”

She said loudly over the din: “What did you want to do?”

He said, “Where are you?”

“Hold on,” she said, and he could hear clicking heels on concrete, picturing her now with one hand cupped over the opposite ear, trying to listen, getting somewhere quiet. She said, “I’m at the docks.”

“The docks? Where?”

“Hamilton. Port Authority.”

“You’re all the way in Hamilton?” It gave him a cold desperate feeling, his wife so far away . . .

“Yeah, we’re down here for a meeting.”

“Who’s we?”

Pause. “Devlin,” she said.

“You’re with Devlin?” And just like that, something cold slithered around his heart. God, and the erection just wouldn’t go away. He squeezed his thighs together.

Kimmy changed the subject. “What did you want to do tonight?”

He said, “I don’t want to bug you—if you’re working, if you’re busy, I’ll ___”

“Our meeting’s over, we’re just taking a tour of the docks right now.”

Taking a tour of the docks? There was something date-like about it, and he could picture Devlin walking with her, showing her the sights, maybe the two of them holding hands . . . He said, “Is Devlin right there?”

“Yeah, he’s right here.”

And then he shushed her—afraid Devlin would overhear Josh talking about him. “Don’t say that near him . . .”

“He’s not listening, Josh—what do you want to do tonight?”

And now she sounded irritated (or was it his imagination?).

He said, “When are you going to be home?”

“I think I’ll be home regular time. We’re heading back soon.”

“Let’s do something fun. I want to spend time with you . . .” And then he had an image, the lure of family again, thinking now they would go see a movie, something PG, bring Meyer and Sophie . . .



When the phone went back in her suit, Devlin was there, hands in his pockets, a summery lake breeze tossing his tie and ruffling his brushed back hair. He squinted into the sun saying to her, “Nice guy Josh checking up on his wife?”

“He wants to go out tonight.”

“Come on,” Devlin said, nodding his chin along the walkway where they’d headed before Josh called. The Mercedes was behind them, a small gleaming black slug aside the mass of the huge container ship. They strolled the concrete walk alongside the squared drop off into choppy Lake Ontario, the walkway separated by a massive chain strung on syncopated metal posts. The sun shone on them, and the heat was nice on her cheeks.

Soon, they’d left the bustle of moving equipment back by the Jourlet and the shipyard was quieter, not silent, but more peaceful. There was a patch of greenery ahead and she figured that was where Devlin would take her to talk, but now he veered inward, toward a low patch of grounded containers sitting around an abandoned forklift. She followed.

They got side by side again, and Devlin said, “You don’t have to apologize.”

“I didn’t—”

“I told you from the start the job was separate. I wouldn’t want it any other way. I mean, I was up front from the beginning.”

“You were . . .”

They paused at the forklift. Devlin leaned a shoulder on it and looked at her. She ran her hand on the sun-hot yellow metal.

When the moment was silent too long, she said, “It’s just . . .”

“Tell me,” he prompted when she paused.

She looked up, met his eyes. “Mel. Mel Wilson.”

Devlin raised his eyebrows. “What about him?”

“You let him go.”

“I did.”

“Before I got here.”

Devlin shrugged, frowned, watched her. Two cargo trucks lumbered their way, big smelly diesel motors churning and roaring. Both of them winced and together saw the roiling dust storm in the trucks’ wake. Devlin led her to the nose of the forklift, took her hand and walked her into the cool dim space of an open cargo container a foot off the ground. He pulled her up and in as the trucks roared past.

The front quarter of the container had been emptied, or not yet loaded, the remaining space packed floor to ceiling with fifty-pound bags stacked on pallets and wrapped in plastic. From the smell, they could be fertilizer.

Devlin, with his hands in his pants pockets again, turned saying, “Yeah. I fired Mel before you started.”

She stood in the line of light from the open cargo door. “You see what I’m thinking?”

“You’re not going to stop thinking of me in this way, are you?”

“What way’s that?”

“I needed you in bed so bad I just pushed out the closest dog to make room for you?”

“I didn’t say that.”

“You think I wanted you in here so I could fuck you. You think I got rid of someone so I could get you in my gunsight.”

“You need two lawyers or one?”

“In Toronto? One. You.”

“So . . .?”

“I need the right person. You’re the right person. When Mel was here, I hired you thinking I might need two lawyers. I only need one.”

“Double the workload for me.”

“You love it. In high school I knew Kimmy Chang always did her homework.”

“I always did my homework. So why is Mel gone?”

“Uh-oh,” Devlin said, flashing a mean smile.

“Uh-oh, what?”

“What’s that type of riddle the bad guy asks if you want to pass?”

“Pass? It’s a neck riddle if it’s to save your neck.”

“Perfect. I have a riddle.”

“To save my neck?”

“Mel lost his job because of it. It’s time sensitive. Are you up for the task?”

“What if I’m not?”

“You tell me.”

She scoffed. “What, you’re going to fire me like you fired Mel?”

“You going to cry on the way out too?”

“You wouldn’t fire me.”

“I hope I don’t have to decide.”

She studied him, showing him confidence while she scrutinized his intent.
“So what’s the conundrum?”

“Border Services seized a load on us. Eighty containers. Mel Wilson fucked up his paperwork, now I’ve got a client with one-and-a-half million of perishables on the dock. Save my client’s money.”

“Where do I start?”

“Kimmy, Kimmy . . . you tell me. I already hired out-of-house. ABM in Toronto’s already working it. Hope you can beat them to the punch.”

She crossed her arms, smirking. “So if I fix it, I don’t have to have sex with you?”

“The job and its performance are always separate from sex. I told you that.”

“I was kidding, Devlin.”

Devlin adjusted his tie, working the knot looser, saying, “The riddle’s a joke, Kimmy. I don’t need you to fix it. I told you ABM’s on it.”

“I can fix it,” she said standing up to him as he pulled his tie free and unbuttoned his shirt. “What are you doing?”

“Solving Kimmy’s riddle,” he said, coming closer.

Expo

With his tie removed, Devlin stood before her with the silk fabric wound over his two large hands. Her heart raced. He wound the tie tighter around his right fist, smirking now. “Turn around,” he said.

She was wordless. Her brain gone cottony and disconnected. All snark removed, wit and cynicism stripped away. Devlin stood a head taller than her, the musky woodsy scent of him overpowering the chemical agriculture smell of the container. His shirt was open, and she could see the tanned skin of his chest and collar. Sunlight came in the open cargo door, painting one side of his face in bright pastel, the pale colors of floral bouquets drawing lines along the edge of his nose, the ridge of his cheekbone, his brow, the sharp angle of his strong jaw. And those hands, the way the softness of the tie’s silk caressed their firm power . . .

She turned around, dipping her chin, looking at the scratched and pitted metal floor, the angled edges of the container’s wall. When he said nothing, didn’t even touch her, she said, “What do you want me to do?”

“Put your hands behind you.”

There was a small clicking sound of protest in her throat, but she closed it off and put first her right hand behind her, then the left. Devlin maneuvered her wrists together, the left one over top of the right one, tugging higher the sleeves of her suit jacket and slipping the fabric of his tie around both wrists, tightening it, tying a knot, looping again and tucking the tie’s dangling ends through. Her arms were firmly affixed behind her back.

“Face me.”

When she came around now, that domineering expression had left his eyes, replaced with a certain pleasure. The dominance was still there, the base layer, but now it was like with her active compliance the next stage of his game would begin.

She whispered, “What are you going to do to me?”

It made him smile, and seeing the dimple form in his masculine cheek got her stomach fluttering. She sighed, leaned back until her shoulder blades touched the metal wall. He loomed closer.

“Well, Kimmy . . .” His hand came to her neck, his thumb tracing a line just under her chin, down her throat, then resting on her collarbone. “I’m going to give you what you want.”

Voice breathless, she said, “What’s that?”

He unbuttoned her shirt, not looking in her eyes anymore, but watching his own hand work. Button after button, tugging then her shirttails so they hung over her skirt. He warmed the flat of his hand on her naked tummy. Her thighs began quivering, and her breath came short and shaky. “What is it I want?” She didn’t even know.

His hand caressed her rib cage, slipped behind her, underneath her shirt, headed to undo her bra. She pinched his hand under her arm saying, “No, don’t.”

“This is what you want, Kimmy. You don’t want to give it to me . . . but you want me to take it.”

Her mouth opened to say No, but stayed silent and agape, no words uttered. All she could think about was the embarrassment when he removed her bra and saw her naked chest.

But she didn’t stop him as his hand moved again, going to the center of her back, unfastening her bra with thumb and two fingers. She pinched her arms again, holding the bra in place.

Devlin took his time, drawing his hand out, running the first knuckle up her sternum, hooking his finger under the front of her bra then tugging it up and free. Her left breast was completely exposed to him, her nipple large, hard, and engorged, a bursting cherry pit on her A-cup. Devlin made a small hiss of appreciation. She closed her eyes, suffered under his gaze, thinking of all those pretty girls with their swaying breasts he'd been with. Hurting inside, waiting to hear what he might say . . .

“Everything about you is beautiful,” he said.

Her eyes fluttered open, peeled up to look at the shipping container's ceiling. She said nothing, breathing in long strong gusts, feeling his hand cup her meager bosom, then the pad of his thumb working over top of her aching nipple. Her knees loosened, and she dipped, tightening her back muscles so she wouldn't slump to the floor.

Devlin's hand left her breast. He stood. “Stand up straighter,” he said, and she dug her heels in the metal floor and pushed her back up the wall, hands tied behind her, breast exposed. From her navel down, she'd gone like warm Jell-O. Her ass muscles loose, uncomplicated. Glowing embers in her belly, damp heat at her core.

Devlin put a hand in the pocket of his suit jacket and withdrew a folded over sheaf of paper money. She chewed her lip, thinking he was going to peel off a few hundreds and offer money to fuck her. She formed complaint and anger but could say nothing.

But it wasn't the paper he was interested in. He tugged the bills free from the gold money clip, put the bills back in his suit pocket.

Now he gripped her neck again, traced the pad of his thumb along the angle of her jaw, caressing the point of her chin, then pushing his thumb into her hung open mouth. She sucked it, closed her eyes. When he pulled it free, she watched then as he took the warm wetness from her mouth and thumb-smear it into the pinch of the folded over metal money clip. His finger tucked into it, widening its mouth, and he placed it over the bud of her nipple.

“Oh no, no,” she moaned, shaking, chin tucked right down, eyes wide and watching, waiting . . .

Devlin eased his finger out and let the natural tension of the clip bite its jaws down on her desperate throbbing nipple. She cried out, knees going watery again and slumping down the wall.

Devlin grabbed the waistband of her skirt, tugged her forward and helped her to stand. With fingers tented on her naked chest, he guided her backward to lean against the wall, every sensation in her body tuned into the wild radio waves emanating from the electric contact made with those metal jaws on that sensitive part of her. She could feel a growing heaviness between her legs. A wet hunger. Her knees shook.

With both hands on either side of her head, Devlin leaned very close and whispered in her ear now: “I want you on your knees.”

Devlin held the lapels of her suit jacket and she complied, lowering before him, Devlin’s grip making sure she didn’t collapse. The points of her knees touched the hard metal. She looked up, kneeling before this powerful man, hands tied behind her back, face upturned and waiting to see what he wanted. Though she knew what he wanted. He smiled. Without being told, her eyes lowered, looking straight ahead at the crotch of his pants. Waited for him to unzip it. Wanting to see it.

Devlin’s hands came together; she watched his pinched thumb and knuckle draw down his zipper. Waited, eager. He fished out his over-size penis, the long thing bending, then let it go to dangle and bob before her. Not hard, but so incredibly enormous. The most perfectly masculine and sexual thing she’d ever seen. A heavy club of pale flesh, enormous and male and not even turgid yet. A frightening and powerful cudgel of sexual domination. It swayed side to side, heavy, veins beginning to rise against its gummy surface while she watched.

Devlin said, “Open your mouth,” and she did. He caressed her neck, guided her to look upright. Their eyes met, and then Devlin hefted his cock and rested it on her cheek. It crossed the corner of her mouth, along the side of

her nose, the end bowing to rest its chin in the cup of her eye. She could feel the line of heat against her skin, lashes on her open eye fluttering, his cock heavy but boneless, like a warm dry cutlet. Devlin smiled, her boss enjoying the juxtaposition of his extra large cock resting on her face. She ran out her tongue, and he drew back his hips, the weight of his manhood sliding across her face, her tongue eager to accept the head.

They worked together, him guiding his hips forward, stuffing with two fingers the head of his cock into her waiting mouth. She took him against her tongue and palate, eyes turned up to his, sucking on that fat corpulent part of his cock. It swelled and pulsed in her mouth; grew larger and firmer.

“That’s it,” he said, holding her ears and caressing her cheekbones with his thumbs. When he was stiff enough to suck, Devlin guided her forward, her weight on the points of her knees, arms flexing and tightening, her hands at the small of her back.

She wanted to please him. Wanted to submit to him.

With one hand on the back of her head, the webbing between thumb and forefinger braced on the base of her bun, he began to fuck her mouth. He grew even larger and harder. Too large to suck properly. She concentrated on the head, narrowing her mouth, tight bursts of flatulent suction as they both worked in unison, hips thrusting, neck and head bobbing. Spit overflowed and ran down her chin and neck. When he leaked in her mouth, she swallowed. Eyes squinted shut, her body tightened like a bow, his cock an arrow running back and forth in the notch of her mouth. She wanted him to come. Wanted to be the one to detonate that explosion of liquid pleasure. Wanted him to know she could do that for him. Wanted most his strong hands on her, wanted his control, wanted his domination.

It went for minutes, her shaping her tongue around his big cock and trying to pleasure him, snorting for breath.

She choked and cried and gagged, knowing finally he was close, knowing she could do it, make him come.

Her head bobbed faster, Devlin fucked her mouth harder. His breath came in quick animal snorts and she waited and waited, wanted it . . . And then he was coming in her mouth. Roaring and stabbing, his size forcing the ring of her lips wide, blasting hot jets against the back of her throat. Her nose flooded with the scent of his sexual brine and she coughed, choked, felt his come burn the inside of her right sinus. But she swallowed. Took all of it she could—though it was a tremendous amount—the excess blurring around her blubbering lips thinned by the girth of his cock, gushing over her chin, down her neck, one warm trickle somehow running in a jagged line toward her armpit.

Devlin roared and roared, still coming, still spurting, but falling exhausted toward her, his forearm banging against the metal wall above her head and making the cargo container hum. She moaned and hummed with his cock in her mouth, her boss panting above her.

Outside, the whirring motor of a crane let something metal fall heavily against something else metal. A truck backed up, its warning beeps distant but sharp. Head pulled back, she jammed her tongue forward to push his cock out of her mouth, gasping to catch her breath. She fell back with her shoulders against the metal wall, his huge pendulous dick dangling in front of her as she gulped for air. She was hot, skin-slick, throat and mouth wetted by saliva and semen.

Devlin chuckled appreciation, and she liked the sound; a sign she'd done well for him. He dipped, hoisted her to stand with his hands shoveled under her arms. Instead of getting her to her feet, he guided her in a counter-clockwise circle till the backs of her legs touched a lone waist high stack of fertilizer bags on a pallet. He hefted her up to sit.

When he loomed close, she turned her mouth away fearing he would kiss her. He pushed her to lay back with his hand on her chest and she allowed it. He guided her knees up and she let him. He hoisted the front of her skirt up to her waist and she didn't protest. Instead, she rocked and writhed on the plastic fertilizer bags. Hungry, desperate, needing his touch. He gripped the inside of her thigh and she cried out. His hand slipped between her legs, cupped her sex, and she closed her thighs on him, her knees touching.

Devlin's hand jostled and jiggled, working his fingers into the folds between her legs, and feeling his hand pushing against her sex got her to gasp a bursting echo of air throughout the container. He chuckled again, began massaging circles against her opening over the satin of her panties, face looming close, eyes watching her. He said, "You ever get this wet before?"

"Yes-ss . . ."

"I think you're lying to me . . ."

"No," she complained, fighting against her folded arms, eyes opening and closing and opening again. All attention on what his hand did to her pussy, catching glimpses of his face then looking at stacks of pallets and the roof of the container.

"I've never seen a woman get as wet as you."

She gasped again, bucking, stomach tightening and bouncing as a trigger mechanism for her impending orgasm clicked. "Please," she moaned . . .

"Please what?"

"Make me come."

With rough hands, Devlin jabbed thumbs under her skirt and jacked it up to her waist, exposing her naked below her belly button. He grabbed her panties, ripped them at her left hip then pulled hard, the fabric scoring down her long leg and hanging at her ankle. He said, "Show it to me."

"What . . .?"

"I want to see Kimmy Chang's little gash."

"No," she whimpered, closing her legs, making her knees touch again.

Devlin stepped back, cock wagging half-hard, shining wet with her saliva and his come. He moved to the container door, opened it wider to let light flood in. He returned, slow, saying, "Open your legs and show me."

“No,” she whimpered again, hands straining to be free, wanting to cover them between her legs.

“I want to see it, Kimmy. Show me.”

She moaned, gasped, arched her back, wrists struggling against the fabric of his tie. She stared at the metal ceiling, heart racing, a tap dance pulse on the right side of her neck. The blood had rushed between her legs; her sex felt heavy with engorged weight, her opening had widened to a yawn in her underwear—she’d never felt so sexual in all her life.

With slow submission, her legs opened. She drew up her feet, high heel shoes folding over against fertilizer bags, opening her legs very wide for Devlin. Showed him exactly what she had between her thighs.

“Fuck, look at that little pussy.”

It was awful. He was disgusting. But he got her stomach tight, and a flock of butterflies lifting up from her sexual core. Her breaths came quicker. Devlin took out his phone, held it up like he would take a picture and she tried to work her legs closed again.

“No. Open them.”

She whimpered, let her knees part, turned her chin up facing away from his camera. Devlin took pictures of her exposed pussy.

“Fuck me . . . God, what a perfect little slit . . .”

The phone tucked in his pocket, Devlin got closer, touched her hipbones, both his large hands resting over them, then his thumbs working over her pubic hair, the curled back right thumb massaging her clitoris, making her mewl and cry out.

“Yeah, you’re going to come,” he said. “You want to come for me? Show your boss how you come . . .”

“Make me,” she said, “God, I love how you make me come . . .”

Cargo

Devlin's large warm hand worked down the flat of her stomach then crested her mound. The back of her thighs and her ass muscles tightened, and she pumped her hips forward to meet his touch. Blood raced between her legs, and her sex throbbed hot. The sound of her wetness was enormous in the metal confines of the container, slick squishing between her legs as Devlin worked his hand forward and back, her humping against it, his fingers weaving between her sopping furrowed membranes.

Devlin said, "I swear I've never seen a woman get so wet."

She gasped, knots of pain blossoming in the fronts of her shoulders as her wrists struggled against the restraint of his silk tie. She writhed on the bags of fertilizer, her heel points puncturing the plastic wrap, her feet locked in place now, pointed knees wagging open and closed as Devlin pleased her with the cup of his palm, creating suction against her opening. And her aperture felt wide and ready to accept his large member. Twenty minutes ago she was telling him she didn't want to do this, and now she was moments away from another one of Devlin's huge orgasms. "Make me come . . ."

"Kimmy wants to come . . ."

"Please, make me come . . ."

Devlin pushed his fingers down between her legs, the pads of his two middle fingers tugging on the bottom yoke of her membranes, massaging against that thin banjo string between her vagina and anus. She held her breath as he teased her anus with his middle finger, pulsing and circling. Then the two fingers came up quick and she inhaled, dropping her ass down

on the fertilizer, Devlin sliding two fingers inside her vagina, spreading her lips wide, going deep, the finger points bounding over her front wall, smoothing out the folds of her corrugated roof.

“God, your fingers are so big . . .”

“Kimmy, you’re so tight you’re crushing my fingers.”

“Make me come . . .”

Devlin was slow and careful and deliberate. Drawing two fingers out, pushing them in, running the points of them over her front wall, whirling typhoons of white light pleasure behind her closed off eyes. In and out, in and out, getting her writhing and squirming, knees opening and closing, the slow-motion flapping of a bird’s wings as she humped against his fingers’ thrusts, wanting him deep, loving the feel of him inside her body. She told him again: “I love the way you make me come . . .”

“I love watching your face when you do.”

She wanted to say No—hated the thought of being studied—but then submitted. Her hands were behind her back, her shirt open, her skirt tugged up; a breast was bared, the nipple bitten hard by the smooth-mouth bite of his gold money clip. He was fucking her with his fingers and she was going to come. It wasn’t time to be shy. Let him have what he wanted.

Her mouth opened and closed as she gasped, surprising soft airy squeaks at the incredible pleasure he delivered. He went slower, then he went faster, then he went too fast and she cried out. Slow again, deep, then deeper. Now from her stomach down she was blazing hot. The container grew dank now, the sex smell more powerful than ammonium nitrate, heavy and funky; the light woodsy musk of Devlin’s cologne suffocated now by the overpowering stench of her pussy. The wetness was unbelievable. The insides of her thighs were slick—she could feel them slick. Rivulets of her juices ran in the crack of her ass. Her butt cheeks were wet; she was sure it was spilling over the fertilizer bags. She’d never been so wet in her whole life.

“Come for me,” he said.

“I’m coming,” she whispered, and the words tightened her stomach as she humped his hand. Devlin gave her exactly what she wanted. The perfect rhythm, the perfect pace, the perfect depth. He fucked her with two fingers—two huge fingers—and then she was rising, high and higher, her ears going soundless and the shut-off space behind her eyes going bright; light as a feather she floated, drew in breath and held it, and then with one sudden crash, she clapped her legs shut tight, a loud flesh-slap, humped forward and threw her legs open, the outsides of her thighs slapping down against the fertilizer bags. She arched her back, and when the thunderclap of orgasm rocketed through her like a lightning bolt, the arch of her back bowed forward and she hunched, chin to her collar, eyes wide, looking between her spread open legs. Devlin’s hand down there glistening with her sex sweat, sparkles of her dew on the dark fabric of his sleeve. His hand pulsed and his fingers thrust deep; his palm pushed down hard on her clitoris and she cried out. All the tight-packed muscles underneath her pelvic floor seized hard in an undulating wave; they tightened while her stomach muscles loosened, then bellowed outward.

“Oh God, oh God, oh God,” she babbled, and then began spritzing all around Devlin’s hand. Shining wet droplets sparkling in the sliver of daylight coming into the cargo container, squirting from her pussy.

She cried, thrust her hips forward, cramps forming from her shoulder blades down the small of her back. She tightened fists behind her.

It kept coming, and Devlin kept fucking with his fingers. Bright streams arced higher now, and Devlin made way for them, stepping aside, closer to her, grabbing the back of her neck and caressing her jawline with his thumb. She rode out overwhelming pleasure with his hand between her legs and her head in the cup of his palm.

He left her whimpering, broken and blown out. She babbled, moaned; tears ran into her hairline. “Oh God, oh God,” she sighed.

“Fuck, you can come,” he said, still stroking fingers in and out of her.

“Holy, oh wow,” she laughed, her stomach bouncing, head falling back.
“Oh my God,” she said, looking up at the roof of the cargo container. Every little touch between her legs got her legs and back jolting like being tickled.
“Ah, ha, mm,” she said, “oh, you’ve got to stop . . .”

With her head in his hand, his face loomed nearer to hers like he would kiss her. He was smiling, his handsome face proud above hers. And in that moment, if he had put his lips to hers, she might have accepted it. But instead he studied her face as his middle fingers explored her opening again, opening her petals, teasing her clit. “Say you want me to fuck you,” he said.

No hesitation: “I want you to fuck me,” she murmured.

“I know you do,” he said, rose a little higher to show her his huge cock at full hardness again. “Tell me to put it in you.”

“Put it in me,” she said, trying to get up on her elbows while her legs opened wider.

He came around between her legs, his cock thrust up hard and impossibly thick, and she noticed while it bowed it also turned the slightest corkscrew. And she wondered what that would feel like driving in and out of her.
“Fuck me,” she whispered.

He put hands on the bags, either side of her waist, looming over her face again and smiling. She looked down, could feel his hardness between her legs. The deep cup of his urethra filled with the white of his cum, spilling a stream on her stomach as he hunched, and he ran his cock back ready to plunge it into her depths.

“Fuck me,” she said, knowing they needed a condom but there wasn’t any time.

He said, “You want to get fucked, don’t you?”

“Do it,” she said, “fuck me.”

The huge plump and shining head of his cock teased at her pussy, slipping up and down, pushing in and pulling out. The backs of her arms and her collar blazed with fire; her scalp tingled and felt peeled. “I want it in me so bad,” she whispered, humping her hips up, trying to get him to put it in her. He pushed the head in, then pulled it out. She cried out, her nails biting into her palms.

Devlin came in for that kiss again, and she raised her chin up and away. He bit her neck, and her nipples hardened, the one still trapped in the bra bitten sharply by the fabric. “Just fuck me, please, Devlin, fuck me . . .” She moaned then a sound of pain—psychic and physical.

Then Devlin was gone.

Her eyelashes fluttered; she worked up onto her elbows again. Devlin was tugging on his pants and trying to get that huge cock tucked inside.

“What are you doing?”

“I’m not going to fuck you on some fertilizer bags, Kimmy. Not the first time, anyway. I want you to remember the first time.”

“I would remember it,” she said, frowning, feeling hurt and mad, and overflowing with disbelief.

He got his fly up, said, “We gotta get back to Toronto.”

She growled, her stomach hurting, her pussy literally quivering, her head falling back. She growled, “Devlin, you are such an asshole.”

Then he was back, looming over her, enjoying his effect. “I got what I wanted.” He pulled sharply on his money clip and it jumped off her nipple with a metallic click. She flinched as a sudden pleasure bolt went from her pained nipple to her pussy.

She made a disgusted sound, said, “Me to suck your cock?”

“Close. It’s what I wanted out of your mouth. Not in it.” He touched her chin and pushed his index finger between her lips. She sucked his finger

and could taste herself on it. He said, “I wanted you to tell me the truth. I wanted you to admit you need me to fuck you.”

She nodded with his finger in her mouth, her eyes on his. Obeying him, and even a tiny glimmer of hope there that the act of sucking his finger and looking in his eyes would change his mind and he would finally give it to her. Though her orgasm had been huge, there were tight knots inside her hip bones that ached with need right now. She wanted to come again and again and again. Spend the whole afternoon in this cargo container.

She tongued his finger out.

Devlin chuckled, stood up over her, pulled the kerchief from his lapel pocket. He unfolded it, dabbed at his finger, then tossed it to cover her sex. “You’re going to have to clean that up if you want to get back in my car.”

“You’re a pig,” she whispered under her breath. The more you said stuff like that, the more he liked it. Dignity would be clawed back here. Louder, she said, “Untie me.”

With the lapels of her suit coat, he pulled her to sit, put his arms around her like a hug, untying the knot of his tie behind her back while she breathed in the hot musk emanating from under his shirt collar. She rested her cheek against his chest and waited.

He stood, winding his tie and shoving it in his pocket. “Fuck, you’re hot,” he said looking at her admiringly with her skirt bunched up around her waist, her naked legs hanging over the bags of fertilizer, one shoe who-knows-where, the other one stuck with its heel stabbed into a fertilizer bag. She rubbed her wrists, worked her neck around, getting the kinks out of her back and shoulders.

Devlin stooped, snatched something up from the floor. Her panties held in one fist. He crumpled them, tucked them in his suit coat’s pocket. “Clean yourself up,” he said. “I’m going to be outside.”

He moved into the sunlight, stepping down and walking away toward the forklift where she couldn’t see him.

Now she looked at her hands, looked at her wrists where they were lined with the tightness of his silk tie restraint. She chuckled, then the sound of her own laughter brought shame and remorse, so she choked it off, hunched forward, took his handkerchief and wiped at her thighs.

“Oh my God,” she said, standing up, looking at her own mess. The seat of her skirt was stained dark on the inside, bleeding right through to darken the other side as well. Her wetness leaked to her knees. She wiped her neck and her mouth, wishing she had two more handkerchiefs to do the job.

Bra done up, shirt buttoned and tucked in, she withdrew her iPhone and checked her face on the screen. Eyes wet and bleary, lipstick totally gone. Cheeks red, freckles blazing. She looked like she got fucked. Hadn’t even been with Devlin’s cock. This is what she looked like after he fucked her with two fingers. Devlin’s two fingers were as big as her husband’s erection.

With that thought, she closed off the phone and pocketed it, stood, straightened, put her feet in her shoes. In the doorway of the container, she saw Devlin now standing in that pose he did, feet shoulder width apart, his back to her, one fist on a hip. He was talking on his phone, saying, “What seats? . . . Yeah? . . . What time? . . .”

She stood there, incredulous, while Devlin made plans with friends to get suite seats at the Jays game.

They’d walked together back to the Mercedes in silence, cocooned in the Port’s cacophony of clanging machinery, the whole while Devlin with a smug and satisfied smile. In the quiet of the cab, Devlin said, “All better now?”

She said, “Give me your phone.”

“What for?”

“You took pictures.”

“I did,” he said.

“Give me your phone,” she said and gave him a stone-serious look.

He held her gaze, vacillating, head cocking, raising his eyebrows, closing his eyes . . . then submitting.

“Fine,” he said, passing his phone.

She brought it awake, aimed it his way, and he craned his face for verification. It opened, she tapped photos, afraid of what she would see there. Sure enough, he really had taken pictures. And there it was, what he’d seen . . .

The photo was mostly dark, except for the vertex of two spread open bright honey thighs and a rosy-brown stripe at its center, topped with a dark comma of her thin pelt. The sparseness of her pubic hair matted and clung to her skin; she was looking at her own vulva in this way for the first time. It was lubricious, and its sight got snakes squirming in her stomach. She looked closer; couldn’t believe that was her. Her face wasn’t seen, just that intimate and secret part of her only shared with her husband.

Her finger hovered over the trashcan icon, ready to dump it. Gone. Dumped another, and another. On the last one, her finger hovered over the trash. This time she swiped up and turned off his phone. “You can have one.” She passed back his phone.

Devlin took it, made a low sound in his chest. He said, “You can’t know how happy that makes me, Kimmy . . .”

Tramp Park

By four o'clock, Josh had enlisted a troop of fun-seekers from Swanson—all with children—but now he wondered how it would look to Kimmy when she arrived. Was it too obvious?

Meyer and Sophie picked him up after work because Kimmy wouldn't get delivery of her new car until Monday. But Josh invited Leah, Samara, and Gabrielle from work and one of Samara's single mom friends tagged along, all of them bringing their young ones over to Pickering for dinner and fun at The Monkey House, an indoor trampoline amusement park. Sure, he was with his cousin and Sophie, but how out of place did he look, the one guy here who didn't have a kid?—And he was the one who set the whole thing up . . . It was likely when Kimmy showed up she would see right through his charade. He could picture himself through her eyes, coming in, seeing him jumping on a trampoline and trying to shoot baskets with Soph, a grown man alone at what looked like a kid's birthday party.

It occurred to him he could lie, say he just tagged along, but he'd been doing that a lot lately. Lying. Or at least leaving things untold. This was a rough time for them as a couple, and he wasn't the only one who knew it. Kimmy was fully aware. Well, not fully aware. There were things he hadn't told her.

One minute Kimmy was looking to get pregnant again, the next she's back on the pill and into the workforce. Capricious, yes, but he got it. She got stuck doing those baskets because Kimmy couldn't be idle, and she wanted out. Baskets wouldn't be her thing. So her brain said: Let's make a baby. It hurt that that wasn't what she wanted either. It's what he wanted. But they'd just gone through a failed pregnancy.

If Kimmy wanted to work, so be it. He'd stand behind her. But he had to find the nerve to be more truthful, and mind the manipulative tricks, juxtaposing his and Kimmy's life with friends of theirs already with children. Kimmy was too smart to be manipulated.

"You tracking Kimmy again?"

Josh's eyes darted up from his Find My Phone app, caught by Meyer looming over his shoulder, sucking iced tea through a paper straw.

"She's almost here," he said, tucking his phone away, feeling only marginally guilty this time in comparison to the other night. They were expecting Kimmy here at The Monkey House, and he was only checking to see how far away she was.

He sat at a heavy black picnic table—two of them pushed together for their party—in a narrow alley of tables that ran along the busy center floor space of the huge warehouse. He sat backwards, his back to the table dotted with baskets and paper plates spotted with French fry grease and smears of ketchup. Gabrielle was behind him on the other side, wiping her eight-year-old's mouth with a napkin, ready to send him back out to one of the trampolines where he hopefully wouldn't bounce himself into sending up his hot dog and fries all over the walls.

Meyer came around to sit beside him on the bench. He scooted over to make room. Meyer slurped iced tea from the extra-large wax paper cup. They watched some kids they didn't know horsing around and giggling on a trampoline across from them. The place's main floor was divided like a grid, square stalls with trampoline floors and low padded walls, everything black except for the neon trampoline surfaces and the padded columns running up to the high rafter ceiling.

Meyer set his cup down, said, "Please, don't tell me you guys are having trouble."

He turned to regard Meyer, who kept his eyes across still. He said, "Me and Kimmy?"

Meyer turned, but didn't look him in the eye. "You guys have always been, like, my idols. I wish I had it with Hyun like you and Kimmy do. I always admired you guys."

"Why do you ask that?" It made him nervous to think there might be something Meyer could see that he couldn't.

Meyer nodded his chin to Josh's lap where he'd been holding his phone. "You checking up on her. All that stuff you said on the weekend. That guy—what's his name, the one from high school, he's Kimmy's boss now . . . Devlin, Devlin Stone . . ."

"Does it sound bad to you?"

"A little, but . . ."

"But what?" he asked, needing to hear more.

Meyer said, "I wouldn't have . . . It's you, you know?"

"What do you mean?"

"I wouldn't have thought anything bad about Kimmy before, her going to work for some guy, some good-looking guy—"

"How do you know what he looks like?"

Meyer shrugged, cocked his head, rolled his eyes up, embarrassed. "I looked the guy up."

Josh laughed. "You did not."

"I was thinking about you guys. I care about you two."

"Thanks, man," he said, touched, thumping a fist on his cousin's thigh. "Okay, what were you saying?"

"I get it. Checking up on her, worrying . . . But Kimmy's not like that. You know her better than I do, I know, but she's . . . Kimmy."

“So you say it’s me?”

“I said I get it. After you told me on the weekend, it got, like, my palms sweaty thinking how you must feel. Fuck, it was terrible with Hyun. God, what a time . . .” Meyer shook his head, face drawn, remembering. “But Kimmy isn’t Hyun.”

“Hyun didn’t fool around on you.”

Meyer shrugged. “Look, Kimmy’s got a good head on her shoulders. I don’t know anybody more in my life who’s got their shit together better. You know what I’m saying . . .”

“I do. I know.”

“Just don’t let bad thoughts get in your head, they can make you do crazy things.”

“You got crazy?”

“I got a little crazy,” Meyer chuckled, rolled his head around to look at Josh. His eyes drifted over Josh’s shoulder. He said quieter, “Hey, what do you think of Quinn?”

“Samara’s friend?” Josh turned to look behind. Quinn was on a trampoline with three kids, both her hands holding onto her son Harley’s. They bounced together. Quinn was a dirty blonde, a nurse, full-figured but petite with a cute face and a button nose. He said, “She’s really cute.”

“You think so?”

Josh turned back. “Careful, though. Named her kid Harley, her ex could be some big biker, out of the picture because he’s in prison.”

Meyer spied Quinn still, smiling, punching Josh’s shoulder saying, “Good old Cuz, always looking at the bright side.”

“It’s a gift,” Josh said, thinking then of his lucky cousin hooking up with Quinn, getting married, having two kids, maybe putting a third in Quinn’s

belly by next winter.

“Didn’t ever think she just likes comic books?”

“Oh yeah . . . Harley Quinn. She’s a nerd like you.”

Meyer steel-eyed him. “Like you too, dummy.”

A bony knee jabbed his thigh, little arms clambering around his neck, Sophie climbing on him. He laughed and braced her before she accidentally got him in the goods. Leah was there, returning from a jump chamber, face shiny with sweat, an entourage of six-to-ten-year-olds still amped and looking for fun. She jabbed a thumb over her shoulder, saying, “All right, you two, your turn . . .”



It would have been smarter to cancel, but she knew Josh was expecting her—sensed he needed her, hidden urgency in his phone call—and after what she’d done with Devlin this afternoon, she wouldn’t let her husband down. So here she was trotting into The Monkey House and she hadn’t had time to stop at home before coming. If she’d wanted to change she’d have had to go past Pickering to home, then come back to Pickering . . . 45 minutes or an hour more. But coming into the huge maze-like warehouse, feeling the cool temperature against her bare legs, made her feel suddenly naked. Under her skirt she wore no underwear. And while in the car it had been a known problem and she’d almost stopped off the highway looking to get deeper into Pickering and locate the Walmart or something, buy some cheap underwear, she thought the extra time would cost too much—figured she could get away without anyone knowing. But now she was here, her stomach tightened with fear. All those rug-rats running around, her wearing high heels . . . it seemed so easy someone would accidentally catch an up-skirt glimpse, and, being a kid, unabashedly blurt it out in front of everyone.

Now she was paused in the wide lobby of the warehouse, the bouncing chaos playing out beyond the half-wall barriers, two teenage cashiers standing at the counter wondering what this woman was doing just standing here. She was split—thinking she'd run out to the car and zip to find the closest place to buy underwear, and her rational mind saying she was being silly, that her skirt was long and no one could see up it, not even kids, come on already, you just feel guilty . . . Maybe that was it. Guilt manifesting in a fearful feeling of exposure. Come on, Kimmy, you could spend all day here with panties on under your skirt and no one would be able to tell you what they look like.

But still, that air-conditioned air tickled her pubic hair right now . . .

She smiled awkwardly at the closest checkout girl and approached. Bought the ticket for admittance and entered then, standing there in a suit looking like a Monkey House corporate exec here to examine the set-up, scanning the crowd and looking for familiar faces. Someone called her name.

Around the corner of the half wall where she stood, the central alley ran, lined with tables and benches. At the far end were concessions with soft drink logos and photos of meal combos. Three picnic tables down she saw Gabrielle, one of Josh's coworkers from Swanson. Though Gabrielle had met her a dozen times at Josh's work functions, Gabrielle looked unsure, frowning, smirking, her wave tentative. But it was the new look and the business suit throwing her off, so Kimmy smiled, called out, "Hey, Gabrielle," and headed her way. Gabrielle wagged a pointed finger to her left, and Kimmy looked that way.

On the other side of a double row of ten-by-ten trampoline spaces, she could see Josh and Meyer and Sophie on a square trampoline, their room with a basketball hoop overhead. Josh was bouncing, holding Sophie, trying to get her higher but couldn't, the little girl was getting heavier. Sophie held the bright green ball with both hands, waiting for the right opportunity to throw while Meyer bounced nearby, ready for a rebound.

Gabrielle cupped hands around her mouth and shouted out Josh's name. The Monkey House was already loud, but Josh heard his name and looked around. He spotted Gabrielle first, then Kimmy, brightening and waving,

getting Sophie to wave with him. Kimmy returned the happy greeting, continuing on to join Gabrielle who said, “Hey, Kimmy, I didn’t think it was you for a second.”

“It’s me, Gabrielle, me and my new haircut. How’s it going?”

“And the suit, too. You look so professional. Yeah, it’s going good. Josh says you got a new job . . .”

She caught up with Gabrielle, her son, Simon, eating a sundae at her side, while she waited for Josh to come around. The whole while a panic flirting at the back of her mind as she tried to stay present in the conversation with Gabrielle. The things screaming for her attention (though she’d earlier triple-checked): another man’s semen is on your cheeks! You’ve got cum on your shirt collar! On your jacket! You smell like sex! . . . But she’d checked herself and added perfume in the car.

Then Josh was there, coming in mid-conversation and snaking an arm around her waist. She covered a hand over his where it held her stomach, eyes on Gabrielle’s still, Gabrielle talking about one of Simon’s teachers nominating Simon for an award—but when Josh’s lips came near, she couldn’t help moving her cheek away. Total fear response—fear her husband would smell another man on her. Josh stiffened and she laughed nervously, acting like she’d avoided his kiss because she’d been engaged with Gabrielle—heck, you’re the one being rude, Josh—and then looked in his eyes before kissing his mouth. Their lips pressed only for a moment, but in that awful second, her most beloved husband’s familiar lips pressed to hers, her mind flooded with the terrible things she’d done with her mouth today. Josh’s lips were pressed to lips that had sucked Devlin’s cock. Devlin had come in her mouth three hours ago, and she hadn’t brushed her teeth in between—though she’d gone through half a pack of Josh’s spearmint gum he kept in the Qashqai. She hid fear from her eyes when their mouths parted, showed Josh a smile. As real as the smile was, it hurt to be so deceptive.

Josh sat and she joined him, Gabrielle tending to Simon’s mess. She shifted side-to-side, tucking her skirt underneath her, Josh watching her strangely for a moment. He asked her how traffic was.

“Brutal,” she told him. “I feel like I was in the car all day.”

“How’s Hamilton this time of year?”

“It was fine,” she joked, nudging her shoulder against him and then leaning. Kids jumped on a trampoline across from them, four boys, and things were getting rough. She said, “Hey, we need to go have lunch with my dad soon, he wants to see us this summer, and it’s almost halfway through August.”

“Maybe we’ll take the new car out for a road trip.”

Not a bad idea. She said, “Big road trip all the way out to Markham?”

“What do you say?”

“I think it’s a great idea,” she said as the four-boy-fun on the trampoline turned to combat and crying. Two mothers came and escorted their boys away. She chuckled, leaned to say something to Josh, but changed her mind. She was going to make fun of them being the only people here who didn’t have kids, and how out of place she felt. But she was pretty sure Josh had arranged this gathering because he needed some kid energy, and that was just like her sweet husband . . .

Fusion

Kimmy couldn't have looked more out of place, and it was the other moms looking bothered that clued him in. The others had greeted Kimmy, some already knew her, and you could see the coldness in their faces. This wasn't the Kimmy they knew. Not the one they were used to. This one was intimidating. And if their boyfriends or husbands were present, their chagrin would be amplified. Kimmy was tall, taller in her heels, and Josh didn't know how much the shoes cost (only knew they were expensive enough Kimmy didn't want to give him the number), but figured the moms would; her legs were long, she was skinny, and now her hair was combed back, shining like it was wet, tied in a bun, exposing her perfect and beautiful face under the long fringe of bangs. She hardly wore makeup; just a little accent on her eyes, a little gloss on her lips; you could see the freckles on her cheeks to prove she didn't have a base of foundation. Gabrielle and Leah had worn suits today, but they didn't have Kimmy's thin figure, nor were their clothes as fine as Kimmy's expensive things. Plus, they'd doffed their jackets, rolled up their sleeves, and untucked their shirts.

Kimmy lounged with her back against the table, facing outward like him, legs tightly crossed like she was cold. She said, "Did you eat?"

"No. Figured we'd eat together, and you probably wouldn't want a hot dog and fries."

"I'm not opposed."

"We can grab Chinese when we're going home."

"I'm starving," she sighed, tightening her crossed arms.

He moved his mouth like he would ask if she and Devlin didn't stop on the way back from Hamilton for a bite to eat, but didn't want to bring him up. "We can get going soon."

"We don't have to hurry."

"Want me to grab you some fries or something?"

"I'm good." Her high heel shoe bobbed, Kimmy swinging her leg. A shapely leg he examined, lusting after his own wife, her oblivious to the way her husband currently studied her. He already knew his luck being with her, and now he enjoyed a moment studying the provocative shape of her knee, calf, and ankle like she was a beautiful woman he didn't know sitting next to him on the subway. Thin legs, raised tendon at her knee, the hem of her skirt was kept low, almost touching her knee; there was a glimpse of inside thigh, just a sliver, on the leg crossing over top the other. He smiled, raised his eyes to appreciate her perfect profile a moment, the shallow ridges, the subdued almost flat prominence of her nose, the pout of her sexy lips, the sharpness of jaw, thinness of neck . . . His eyes returned to the exposed leg, a swelling beginning between his own legs, a desire to get her home building . . .

In the glare of the high-mounted fluorescents, he detected a gauzy haze on her skin that otherwise gleamed. He reared back, trying to change the light's reflection. Yeah, there was a barely noticeable dullness there, inside of her left knee, and it made him think of Gabrielle cleaning Simon's mouth of ice cream and missing a spot, or smearing rather than clearing. He cocked his head, saw the hazy shape's irregular edges, the vague outline reminding him of a jigsaw puzzle piece.

When he cupped a hand on her bare knee, Kimmy jumped. He laughed, thumb-caressed her kneecap to soothe her. She pressed her crossed legs together tighter and tugged the hem of her skirt lower, trying to get it over her knee. He still chuckled, wiping his thumb to clear the mark. There was no strange feel under his thumb pad, and he cocked his head to see if there was a change to the duller sheen. Kimmy caught him looking, squirming now to see what he spied. "Don't, Josh," she said, annoyed.

“I’m not doing anything,” he laughed.

“Not in public,” she said without humor, licking three of her fingers, shoving his hand away and wiping where his thumb had been.

“I’m not doing anything,” he said again with less laughter this time. Kimmy crossed her legs over the other way now and tugged her skirt hem low. Like she was self-conscious of dressing so well when everyone else here at the Monkey House dressed so casually.

From the central alley’s end, Meyer and Sophie had come to their group, Meyer lifting Sophie up by both hands to stand on the picnic table bench. Sophie trotted straight to her favorite aunt, coming to Kimmy’s back and putting her little hands on Kimmy’s bun, looking to undo it. While he watched and said nothing to Kimmy as Sophie approached, it was because he expected Sophie’s presence to remove Kimmy’s scowl—but instead, Kimmy almost shouted, her face pinching mean as she darted forward, hands coming up protectively to the sides of her head. “Don’t do that,” she hissed, clucking her tongue, standing up, scoffing, straightening her skirt.

Kimmy turned, saw it was Sophie; her posture sagged. Sophie stood on the bench still, both hands gathered under her chin, eyes widened from being scolded unexpectedly, sucking on her lower lip. Kimmy hung her head, palmed her brow for a second, then showed a face full of apology. She took Sophie in her arms, sitting back down next to Josh again, one hand caressing the back of Sophie’s head. “I’m so sorry, Sophie, I didn’t know it was you.”

“Sorry,” Sophie said, and Kimmy shushed her, not wanting her to apologize, hugging still. Josh met Meyer’s eyes where he stood at the end of the table, hands in his pockets. They both shrugged.

“Go—do it,” Kimmy said to Sophie now, spinning, showing Sophie her back. “Make me look normal again.”

The hurt feelings were forgotten, and Sophie giggled, began working fingers through Kimmy’s hair.

Kimmy showed him a grimace that turned sheepish, and he laughed, palmed her knee where it touched his thigh. Kimmy put her hand over his.

Sophie worked the bun loose and Kimmy shook her hair out, running nails through her bangs to mess them up. Sophie hugged arms around Kimmy's neck and pressed her chin into her collar.

"Now I feel like myself again," Kimmy told her, caressing Sophie's forearm.

"Come jump with me," Sophie said. The spot across from them where the boys had fought was empty still. Inviting.

"I don't think I can, Soph. I don't have the right shoes." And, no, she didn't, her heels would go right through.

Sophie said, "Take off your shoes."

Kimmy said, "I don't think so, Soph, they don't want bare feet on there, do they?"

Josh said, "They wouldn't want my bare feet on there, nobody's going to care about your pretty feet . . ."

Kimmy shot him a disdainful look. "But . . ."

"Plea-ease," Sophie pleaded.

Meyer said, "Go on in your bare feet, Kimmy—who's going to stop you? You look like you own the place." He helped Sophie down, and she took Kimmy's wrist; not tugging, but gently guiding, showing Kimmy an expression of pleading.

"Kimmy, just get out there," Josh laughed, leaning away and giving her room to get up.

She did. Reluctantly.

Sophie led her across to the trampoline, bounding ahead and showing her how you were supposed to do it. Meyer took Kimmy's spot on the bench next to Josh. Together they watched Kimmy stiffly finding her bounce, hands on her skirt like she was afraid it might fly up. Kimmy looked nervous at first, but soon was persuaded by Sophie to get into it. And while eventually Kimmy flung her jacket aside and bounced in her sleeveless top (showing off her toned arms), she still seemed stiff. It was strange, because fun Kimmy from two weeks ago would probably have tried a backflip for Sophie, skirt or not.

In the car on the way home, he laughed at her for trying to be a big shot, and she defended herself, not thinking it was as funny as he did.

"But I wasn't," she said. "I wasn't trying to be . . ."

"Showboat Kimmy," he called her.

Back at the Monkey House, Quinn's little one had bounded into the group, pleading to go into the arcade. The arcade was a separate quadrant of the warehouse, with skeet ball, prize claws, and you could buy or win tokens for video games you sat in, or rode on like ninja bikes. It got others wanting to go as well—but the moms were telling them they were supposed to be bouncing, maybe another time for the arcade . . . Because going into the arcade took a different ticket—\$12 a head, which included forty tokens, but tokens cost fifty cents apiece after that if you couldn't win them. There'd been hassled discussion, and it looked like the moms might capitulate, and Meyer was saying he wanted to go too . . . And then Kimmy announced anyone who wanted could go to the arcade, her treat. A very nice and wonderful gesture from one of the kindest women he knew, but . . .

"Don't call me that," Kimmy said.

"Sorry," he said, then, "Showboat," as he turned into the plaza where the Good Taste Chinese restaurant was—though they'd ordered combos from their Guyanese menu.

When he got back in the car with the stapled bag of food, Kimmy said, “Was it that bad?”

“The arcade?—No, Kimmy,” he said, winding the car out of the parking lot, waiting at the traffic light. “You paid for everybody—what?—seven kids plus that really big kid, Meyer, that’s like, what’s eight times \$12?”

“I didn’t pay for Meyer.”

“I think you did—I think he snuck in on your dime. Kimmy, I’m only joking, anyway. I’m trying to be funny. You’re awesome, I mean it. I’m so glad you were there.”

“Was it what you needed?”

He looked her way, Kimmy sitting in the passenger seat, her haircut returned to normal but still wearing her killer suit. His heart swelled watching her. Of course she could tell he needed that. “It was,” he said.

“I just wanted everybody to like me. I was getting a vibe.”

“Oh yeah? I guess I’m the one has to tell you . . .”

“Tell me what?”

“Kimmy, I don’t know how to say this”—building up the drama—“you look like a supermodel the movie company hired to play a Bond girl right now.”

“You’re so goofy.” She laughed.

“I felt ten-feet tall with you there as my wife.”

“Uh-huh,” she said, shaking her head like he was silly.

“Single moms, Kimmy, they see you dressed like that, looking like that, you’ve got this awesome husband everybody likes . . .”—Kimmy chuckled—“. . . dropping a hundred bucks to pay for some fun for their kids is the

sweetest thing, but it might be a hundred bucks they don't have and while I know you're the kindest person in the world, they might see it different."

Kimmy sighed, pushed back her hair. "Everybody's all about resentment these days . . ."

They chatted the few minutes home, and he liked where they were at, so he didn't mention how her day might've been with Devlin down in Hamilton.

In the foyer of their apartment, Kimmy stood with her back to him at the tall table under the photo of the Lungshan Temple in Taiwan. He set their bag of food down next to her purse, and she turned her head to the side. His arms went around her, and she leaned against him.

That simple act of affection altered all his brain chemicals, sweeping away the hunger he had despite the delicious grease smell emanating from the bag from Good Taste. The only hunger he felt right now stiffening at his core and his hugging arms tightened, pressing his bulge against Kimmy's ass. And his wife didn't squirm, didn't resist. She caressed his hands.

They were both hungry; Kimmy'd said she was starving, but suddenly it would seem the both of them had different things on their minds.

His hands explored, going underneath her suit jacket and touching her chest and stomach over her shirt. Kimmy's breaths deepened.

Near her ear, he said, "When I saw you come in tonight I couldn't believe you were my wife."

"I must've looked a real mess before . . ."

"I know how lucky I am, Kimmy, but now you're really rubbing it in everybody else's faces . . ."

She laughed, the laugh trailing to a breathy sigh. Lust in Kimmy's voice. Were they really going to do this now?

He said, “You look so beautiful tonight, I can’t believe how lucky I am . . .”

“Tell me more,” she whispered, her fingernails lightly scratching his hand over her breast.

He squeezed and could feel the hardness of her nipple under her shirt, under her bra. “You’re so turned on,” he said.

She asked, “What are you going to do to me?”

And the last time she challenged him like this, he’d wilted. Right now his cock was hard and pressing into her, and he was full of ideas, full of all sorts of things he’d love to do to her right now. So he told her. “Bend you over this table and fuck you until you scream.” A thing unlike he’d ever said before.

She chuckled. “Josh-sh,” she said, chuckling right through it. “Not in the hallway . . .”

“Oh? Not in the hallway?” His hand dipped low, touching the front of her skirt. She flinched and grabbed his wrist. “I’m going to bend you over and fuck you against this table.”

“Josh, don’t.”

“Oh, you don’t like that?” he said slyly, digging the hump of his erection into her. He tried to press a hand to the center of her back and guide her forward, but she stiffened and wouldn’t bend.

He said, “We’re going to do it right here.”

“Not here,” she said.

“We’re going to start here, maybe we’ll take a tour of the kitchen before we end up in the bedroom.”

She said, “Just the bedroom.”

“I don’t think I can wait that long, Kimmy,” he said, his hand going down the front of her thigh as he dipped at the knees. When he touched the bottom of her skirt, she jumped, dug her nails into his forearm and tried turning around. He got rough, trying to hold her in place, but she still struggled.

“Josh, don’t . . .”

“I want you so bad . . .”

Her tone had changed, though her words sounded the same: “I want to, Josh, just don’t . . .”

“Don’t what? You asked me—” frustrated now “—what you wanted me to do to you . . .”

“I want to know,” she said, “but . . .”

“But what?” he said, surprised how fragile his feelings were. Thirty seconds ago he was ready to go to town, and now he felt wounded, hit with an arrow and limping off the battlefield. “Did you want to eat first?” he said, his tone sarcastic.

“Come here,” she said, turning around, pressing her ass to the table and slipping her arms around his waist. “Just kiss me.”

“You told me what you . . . You said to tell you . . .”

“I want you, Josh, I do . . .”

He kissed her neck, hands roaming, touching her waist, moving down her thigh again . . .

She grabbed his hand. “Josh, don’t . . .”

“Don’t what, Kimmy?”

“Let’s go to the bedroom,” she whispered.

“Yeah, fine,” he said, stepping back, showing his palms, an incredulous look on his face.

“Josh, don’t be like that.”

He said, “Tell me what you want.”

Her brow crinkled, then softened. “I want you so bad right now. I do.”

“Okay . . .”

“Let me put on that lingerie. I want to be sexy . . .”

“Kimmy, come on,” he said, rolling his head on his neck. “I just told you how sexy you are.”

“Would you just listen to me? I told you I want to put on the lingerie . . .”

While his posture slumped, he lowered his chin and looked at her. “Put on the lingerie,” he said, “I want to see you in it.”

“I want to do this, Josh, just not in the front hall . . .”

“Okay,” he said, “go get the lingerie on. I’ll put this—” he waved at the bag, not thinking of the words “—whatever . . . food in the oven . . .”

She said, “Meet me in the bedroom, okay?—I’m sorry . . .”

Trickle Down

In the bathroom, she stood staring at her reflection in the mirror, ears attuned to what her husband was doing on the other side, heard him coming into the bedroom, worried he'd jostle the door knob . . .

She shook her head, admonishing her reflection, biting her lower lip, then moved quickly. Set the bundled lingerie onto the bathroom counter, unbuttoning her suit, the shirt, disrobing, then unzipping her skirt and hesitating. Looking in the mirror, imagining what Josh would think if he'd got her skirt down in the front hall . . .

The skirt dropped, and she regarded her naked body. No underwear. Her underwear belonging to Devlin now. A frisky V of pubic hair between her legs. And with the skirt off, she smelled her sex. It was Josh's actions in the front hall, of course, getting her sex motor running again—but with that renewed excitement wetting her folds, the powerful aftermath of what Devlin had done before became reinvigorated.

Right leg twisted out, she examined the inside of her thigh. Didn't see any marks there, but didn't see any in the cargo container either, nor checking herself in Devlin's passenger seat on the drive home. But eagle-eye Josh had seen something on the inside of her leg. What were the chances? Why would he be looking at the inside of her thigh like that? And what had he seen? She didn't see it. What was it? Nothing? Residue from her squirting? Did she miss a stream of Devlin's semen that had landed there without her knowledge?

No, Josh would've lost it right there in the Monkey House. But holy cow, talk about cutting it close . . .

“What on earth are you doing?” she said to the mirror. And what was she doing? How had it come to this? There in her most true self—though she avoided it—she knew that she would sleep with Devlin. But for whatever reason, nothing about how she felt about Josh was changed. In fact, somehow she loved him more than ever. Couldn’t wait to get into the lingerie; couldn’t wait to see his face when he saw her in it; couldn’t wait to skip dinner so they could make love.

The smell was too much. She covered her face in her hands, breathed into them for almost a minute, the soft scoring sound against her palms soothing her. There was so much to this, so much more than just submitting to Devlin. Submitting to Devlin was easy, it was the lying to Josh that was going to destroy her. The subterfuge . . .

The worst part was how good she thought she might be at it. Even now, laying over top the sexy lingerie folded on the counter, she’d brought something else into the bathroom . . .

But the only way she could have sex with her husband tonight, with a clear and unbridled passion, was to get in the shower. So she did . . .



They’d married the summer after Kimmy’s first year of law school. An absolutely awesome time where they finally felt like adults. He’d got the job at Swanson in March, had his own apartment in Ajax. Kimmy’d been living in London for school and they only saw each other on the weekends. It wasn’t an absolutely awesome time while it was happening because they’d been used to having an apartment together in Kingston in their last year at Queens, then with Kimmy at law school out west they were separated. In retrospect, now he missed those days so filled with glowing promise.

He'd had a job in Toronto for a year, and it wasn't going anywhere. Then he landed at Swanson, even further away from Kimmy. He'd hung out a lot with Meyer and Hyun and baby Soph; Kimmy'd studied twenty-four-seven in her little apartment off campus. But that June they got a taste of what their life might be like as they got closer to their dreams. A wedding. A honeymoon. A summer with the two of them in the first Ajax apartment together. A married couple.

A moment stood out from that summer of 2015. It was of him standing outside the bathroom door the night before she moved back to London for the start of her second year. A hollow door separated them, but somehow they shared their silent sorrow across that divide. He'd heard her crying, and he'd stood on the other side of the door with his palm on it, feeling her pain, maybe trying to absorb it, tears on his cheeks. Two weirdos who loved each other but wouldn't confront each other's feelings or show each other their hurt. Two people suffering apart, doing it alone so they wouldn't burden the other. When the door'd opened, they'd both already cleaned their faces, showed smiles like nothing'd happened and went to bed together, cuddling and happy, that sick and hurting moment separate from who they were as a couple.

And now, standing here waiting for her to come out in lingerie, he had that hurt again. But it was dark and low and profound now. It was heartache and jealousy and coppery love.

Just like that summer night on opposite sides of the door, both of them lamenting the close of their long happy summer of togetherness, he stood in the bedroom, Kimmy in the bathroom, and the fear this time again was about separation. Not distance, but Kimmy drawn to another man. Not love. Never love. Not for Devlin Stone. But whatever Devlin had, the pull was strong, and Kimmy was being drawn into his orbit. He could feel it. It was crazy not to feel it.

At the foot of his bed, staring at the door, listening to Kimmy on the other side, he was naked. Shirt bunched at his side, pants kicked off, erection sticking out straight, dozing but ready for action. Kimmy was in there now, putting on lingerie for him. She'd never worn lingerie before a month ago. That was new. But why had she not wanted to do anything in the front hall?

There were things that were obvious, and he was denying them. She'd been with Devlin all day. Been in the car with him all day.

She'd fucked him.

It wasn't impossible.

Remembering her now bouncing on the trampoline with her hands between her legs, trying to keep her skirt from flying up. Was her tight pussy sore? Had she been fucked hard by a big man? Kimmy wasn't used to it. She couldn't bounce because it hurt between her legs . . . And, oh Jesus, here it all came now: the smear on the inside of her knee. Devlin's semen. She'd fucked him, and he'd come inside her. It had leaked down her leg, and she'd wiped it with a tissue. Left a smear.

With his heart hammering in his chest, he stared dumbly down now at his own hand, looking at the curled-back pad of his thumb. He'd smeared Devlin's semen on his wife's knee, trying to clean her. That's what it was. Wasn't it?

Prove yourself wrong.

He couldn't. Why else would Kimmy act that way?

Were they fucking when he called? She'd said Devlin was right there. Said, "He's not listening." Were the two of them in the back seat of Devlin's car, both of them on their phones? Kimmy talking to her dumb oblivious husband, her skirt around her ankles, her pussy widened and fulfilled and oozing another man's semen . . .? . . . Devlin checking the stock market, chuckling to himself about what he'd just done to that dumb nerd Josh Waters' wife . . . Did Devlin's car even have a backseat? . . .

Fuck.

Didn't even need to look down, because there were new changes that should alarm him, but to which he was growing accustomed. A thundering-horses-across-the-plain blood flow raced through his cock. What had moments ago stood outright and ready, was now more fully engaged than

ever. Too ready. Too hard. It hurt. Upright, pointing to his chin, plump and red and angry and ready to burst, bobbing with his heartbeat, full of lust and intent; a steely prong independent of his body, like another man in the room, a separate throbbing presence.

The idea of Kimmy with her legs open and Devlin thrusting in and out of her . . .

He whispered, “What the fuck . . .?”

Then came the worst sound ever. The shower turning on. Kimmy whisking back the shower curtain. Getting in the tub. Needing to scrub away all of her infidelity’s evidence.

Two mindless steps back and he sat at the foot of the bed, still staring at the door. Woozy, awestruck. Harder than ever . . .



The kimono hung open because she liked the way that looked in the mirror. Standing now, out of the shower and dressed, examining her reflection but avoiding her eyes. She wore the lingerie; little black triangles over her breasts, the panties with their scoop-back cut, the garter belt holding up thigh-high stockings. And, for Josh’s sake, she wore the high heel shoes, too.

Her wavy hair hung in sheets on either side of her face—there’d been no time to wash and dry—and she held a grip of locks now in a hand and pressed it to her mouth and nose. Hard to say. Was there a smell? She imagined she smelled fertilizer. Imagined she smelled other things, too. Not her sex smell, but still: saliva, maybe semen . . . She held a sheaf of her hair on the other side, inhaled that now as well. Still hard to say.

So much guilt welled inside her it could take over, tell her untruths. She wet her hands under the tap, pushed back her hair again, then tied it in a tail. Her long bangs almost hid her eyes. It was good.

The two halves of the kimono hung open, showed off the long flat expanse of her stomach, her tight navel. That's where Josh's attention would be. And if it wasn't there, she would get his attention in other ways.

She withdrew the kimono's belt, rolled and plopped it on the sink. Gave herself one last look and opened the bathroom door . . .

Josh sat naked at the foot of the bed with his legs apart and a bundled T-shirt plopped over his crotch. She posed, putting one foot out and pointing her toes, bracing hands on the inside of the bathroom door frame. She smiled, let him know this was going to be good. And it was going to be good. It deserved to be good.

She crossed the distance between them on high heels. Higher than what she would normally wear, but with a few days experience now, her gait was steady. The high-heeled shoes showed off the tone she worked so hard for, going to the gym and doing yoga. And Josh was mesmerized, his face frozen like mid-shock, his eyes darting all over her body, appreciating it. With slow strides, she came to stand between his open legs. Hands on his shoulders, she ran her thumbs up and down the sides of his neck. She said, "Move that shirt away."

Josh nodded, mouth open, breath shallow. He tossed aside the shirt, and his erection wagged stiffly between his legs like a door stopper. It was a relief to see him fully and completely hard. Incredibly hard. She put forward a knee and ran it up and down the belly of his erection.

"Look how hard you are."

He nodded.

She said, "Stand up."

Josh rose, and she stepped back. In her heels, they were the same height, and she looked deep into his eyes and cupped his cheeks. Their faces came closer, and she kissed him. A deep and loving kiss, her heart swelling in her chest for him . . . and now it was like their mouths were conduits for that love. Her breath grew deep and hungry, and so did his. She pulled back; her smile full and wide. She bit her lower lip, looked in his eyes again. All she wanted right now was to do for him what Devlin had done for her. To give Josh what she'd received from Devlin. To make him come in that way Devlin had made her come.

She pulled herself closer, whispered in his ear: "I'm going to get on my knees for you . . ."

Good Taste

Eyes turned up to the ceiling now, Kimmy's kisses crossed his collar, down his chest, the point of his erection catching on her bra then bouncing up to fall warm against her bare chest. She kissed his belly, worked her mouth down to his cock then took him fully, right inside her mouth all the way until he felt her tongue flatten on his scrotum. His legs shook, he sighed a long moan.

Kimmy pleased him, but that ceiling above him, that white stucco space, was like a screen for an awful film projection. Kimmy with Devlin today. All day. His worst nightmare come to life. All the chances he had to stop it, and he never got in the way. Now he was sure that Kimmy had fucked him. Or Devlin had fucked her.

Thinking now of her jumping in bare feet, wearing her sexy suit, the long blades of muscle in her calves flexing as she went up and down on the balls of her pretty feet . . . The way her hands clutched between her thighs. Thinking now how her pussy would be ravaged. How that thing of Devlin's he'd seen—whether real or not—would plunge in and out of her. Kimmy was tall but slight. A thin girl who was tight on Josh's size. And even if dream-Devlin wasn't real, he'd seen what Devlin had many times before. Knew that what he pictured in that tent at the high school reunion wouldn't be far off . . .

"No, Kimmy, no," he said despite the overwhelming pleasure. Eyes closed, shaking his head, he dipped down, took Kimmy under her arms, helped her to stand. She was unsure, maybe a little worried, wondering why on earth he would stop her from doing something like that. On her knees for her husband. She wiped at her blubbery lips with the back of her hand,

trembling pupils on his darting side-to-side. He gripped her arms tightly, pulled her into a kiss.

“I fucking love you so much,” he said before their mouths connected, and he took the slickness of her lips in his mouth. She gave him her tongue, and he could taste the salt from his own manhood. It was pressed now against her stomach, slippery with her spit, sliding from side-to-side against her.

The grip he had on her arms eased, slid down her forearms and gripped her wrists. His right hand touched her hip then lay flat on her stomach. Their tongues worked together as he dove his hand down the front of her panties. Kimmy gasped into his mouth and her knees sagged. His hand wove through the tuft of her pubic hair and into the warm wet flesh between her legs with a slick sound. Kimmy was sopping in a way he couldn't ever remember feeling before. Overflowing. But overflowing for him. He ran two fingers through the hot folds of her membranes, back and forward, finding her opening and teasing into her. But Kimmy didn't complain, didn't close her legs and tell him no. She didn't say “Ow,” or “I just want to suck your cock,” she pushed her hips forward. She wanted him.

He pushed fingers inside her and still no testament to soreness emanated from her perfect mouth. Two fingers slid inside her with ease. The tightness was there, but his wife was so wet he might be able to put anything inside her right now. He fucked her with his middle fingers, and Kimmy fell against him, her legs shaking, her hands caressing him. “You're so wet,” he said.

“I want you bad,” she said.

“Come on,” he said and they turned aside together, both of them putting knees on the bed. They knee-walked, looking to head toward the pillows, and Kimmy got ahead of him on all fours. He flicked aside her kimono and saw her bare ass cheeks under the black embroidered scoop of her panties. The strap of her garter ran across the taut flesh of her rump and he groaned at the sight. This was his wife. This was the girl he loved since high school. The one he first kissed in 11th grade and pined over when she went away to Taiwan for the summer. The one he stayed in constant contact with until they officially dated the second year at Queens. The one who'd been in his

bed for years. Stood on the altar and said, “I do.” Here in bed with him now. She was his. There was danger for sure. But what she showed him now was honest and real. This wasn’t an act. There were all sorts of awful things he could think of (and he would indulge if he liked, because, for whatever reason, it made him hard) . . . Like maybe Kimmy was so wet right now because she liked sitting in the car with Devlin. His \$150,000 roadster, probably watching his hand on the transmission, sitting there for hours . . . what did they talk about? What had they done all day? It wasn’t all work. It couldn’t be. They’d been together . . . And now she was wet. But in his bed.

He grabbed her hips to stop her crawling. She paused, tossing a look over her shoulder at him. He ran his hand over the small of her back, feeling the silk of her skin, watching her respond to his touch. The sway of her hips, her eagerness . . .

It had to be now; he ran a finger under the crescent hem of her panties, down where they thinned between her legs, found the slickness against the back of his finger where she was a woman, tugged the panties aside, curled over her back, and pushed his cock inside her. Kimmy let out a low appreciative moan, turning her face up, him watching over her shoulder, seeing her eyes close, a natural flutter in her eyelids. It was pleasure. Kimmy wanted him inside her. And she didn’t cry out as if she’d been pummeled today by Devlin’s much larger size. She was tight on him, wet, overflowing wet, but tight as ever . . .

“God,” he said, “You feel so good . . .”

Kimmy said, “You’re so hard, Josh, oh my God, you’re so hard . . .”

And if he thought he couldn’t get harder, he was wrong.

He said, “You make me hard, you make me so hard,” caressing her throat, beginning to stroke in and out of her.

She sighed, “You feel so big . . .”

Those words went across him like a slap and a backhand. Hurt, angst. Pride, too, waking him with her honest expression and appreciation of how hard

he was. He was harder and therefore bigger than normal. True, but at the very best, Kimmy had seen Devlin's bulge for real. That was true because she told him. And her husband wasn't big. Not small, but definitely not to be confused with big. Kimmy knew what big was. Had seen it, even if just through a pair of pants. And she'd been with that man today, and if she got wet for that man, like he imagined, she considered the huge size of another man's penis. It was certain. Kimmy was thinking of her husband's size because she'd been thinking of Devlin's size today.

Now he was wild with passion. Up on his knees, gripping the very narrow and tight waist of his wife and pounding into her hard from behind until the crotch of her panties burned the left side of his steely erection. He was twisted with hurt and wonder and jealousy and rage, but over top of it all was a low-oxygen high-altitude love for the most incredible woman who'd been with him for so long. Love for her, but worse: a love for her sex compartmentalized, individualized and separate from how he knew her. Fucking her pussy now like it was a separate thing. Like his cock was a separate presence in the room, now what she had between her legs was divided from who he knew her as a woman.

It was pure biological pleasure. Hard thundering cock plowing in and out of soft velvety succulent woman flesh . . .



Josh had never before been as savage as this. She needed it this way right now.

It was awful, but this position with her husband was one she'd already fantasized about with Devlin. Impersonal and sex-focused, it was a way to part care and compassion from animal lust. This was the way Devlin would take her. Face hidden away, uncaring, hoggish, getting only the one thing she wanted from Devlin. And never knew she wanted.

It would be only one time. One time for real. In Devlin's car outside her gym didn't count. That wasn't sex—even though they both came, that was still just fooling around. Even today, that wasn't sex . . . One time she would have sex with Devlin. It would be done, Devlin could be pushed off, separated, he'd find some other girl and a year from now she'd and Josh would have money in the bank, on their way to their future, and the thing Amy'd teased her about would be done and forgotten.

And now at the most inopportune time, the awful incident with Amy: the two of them bracing her unsteady husband at Tiffany's party, Amy looking away while Kimmy got Josh's penis out so he could pee—and found her husband erect. Her holding his penis, Josh's stream spritzing, sputtering, sprinkling the bushes. Amy's giggle. Looking up to find Amy peeking, eyes on Kimmy's fingers aiming Josh's penis. Amy saying, Aw, poor Kimmy, you had your chance and now look what you're stuck with.

Josh's grip on her sides was tight, his thrusts hard. She'd closed her eyelids tight enough now to set sparkles behind her eyes. Her face twisted in the sheets, enjoying her husband, and hating the fantasy of another man. Josh was hard as iron right now. Uncomfortable, almost. His penis stabbed into her. Devlin didn't stab, he bludgeoned. They didn't have sex, but she knew what it felt like to have her insides filled by him. Knew what it would feel like when he put it in you for real. He wouldn't poke, he would devastate.

One time . . . just one time with him, and then it would be done.

There was still time to turn back, but she couldn't deny her lust had been provoked.

Everybody messes around, Devlin had said. And it was true. Just one time, that was all.

Play only. No sex. What happened with that rule?

That had been the rule—but today at the Port she'd opened her legs for Devlin. He'd got her hotter than she'd ever been in her whole life—aftershocks all afternoon—and she'd told him to put his big sperm-covered

cock inside her without a condom. What were you thinking? . . . what was it about Devlin that was so irresistible? God, the way he made her come . . .

And now she pictured the huge plump head of his cock as it had stroked at her opening today, covered in slick saliva and semen, so huge but both of them well-lubricated and ready . . .



“Harder,” Kimmy said, her words widening his unseeing eyes.

The room spun; a hazy, topsy-turvy boat on choppy waters. “Harder,” he agreed, tightening his stomach and pounding her.

“Deeper, Josh, God, oh deeper . . .”

Now he exhaled, somehow hurt but liberated—because that was exactly what he wanted to hear right now. “You . . . want it . . . deeper?” His words came individually, animal grunts.

“Deeper, Josh, harder, mm, deeper . . .”

“Ah, Kimmy, you feel so good . . .” She was tight, her grip on him squeezing with eagerness; he was sure she was flexing her stomach and ass, trying to crush his cock as it speared in and out. The pleasure was bewildering. His own stomach tightened and he felt the first tickle of orgasm.

“Josh,” she said, gasping, then hissing: “Don’t stop, don’t stop . . .”

“Ah,” he said, biting his lip, fucking her harder, feeling the pressure rise, “I’m not . . . ah, no, no condom . . .”

“Don’t stop,” she cried, “Deeper, Josh, deeper . . .”

Harder was all he could manage. And now it was all over. Him fucking his wife hard from behind, his wife acting wild in bed in such a crazy unfamiliar way. He lost his grip on control, and the orgasm swelled within him to bursting.

“I’m going to . . . mm, come . . .”

Kimmy made a disappointed moan, then clucked her tongue—it stabbed him in the heart, but did nothing to squash the sexual explosion already under way. He wanted to apologize—wanted to go deeper and harder, too, but it wasn’t going to happen. He said, “Your pill . . .” Meaning: had it taken effect yet.

“Don’t stop, oh, don’t . . .”

Kimmy stretched out now, lowering her cheek to the bed, putting her arms above her head and he watched her long graceful hands grab the pillows where they lay their heads at night. They formed shaking fists, and the lamp light winked a star off of her diamond wedding ring. Completely his. So completely his. Smart, beyond smart, sexy, honest, completely his . . .

“I’m going to come in-inside you . . .”

She gasped, said: “Do it—come inside me, do it,” and now she began rocking on her knees, thrusting her sex back at him, and as the pressure overflowed from his testicles and they rolled up inside his body, he thought again of her thrusting back wanting that male penetration deeper (wider, bigger, harder) and he came in a wicked overloaded generator flash of white hot electric passion.

He grunted, bolted, hands slipping off her, falling with his chest over her back, as incredible overwhelming love for Kimmy burst bright behind his eyes. He came, and spurted inside her, stabbing, humping, his cock popping out, seeing underneath her a dashing line of his semen land in the bedding. He pushed it back in and she let out a satisfied moan, pushed back to get him in her as deep as he could go.

They collapsed together on the bed, him falling at her side, Kimmy rolling to her back. He watched her gasping profile, those pouting lips open but squeezing into an oval shape over and over, chuffing air. She was fingering herself.

On her back with knees up, feet flat on the bed, Kimmy sought more pleasure—like he hadn't satisfied her. Her high-heeled shoes had fallen off and lay on the bed, one upright, the other on its side. He looked at her stocking toes curling, her knees bowing in and out, one hand shoved in the front of her panties, the other hand holding her own wrist. He watched two knuckles dent up and down under the embroidered fabric.

“No, Kimmy,” he said, “me, let me . . .”

He pushed his hand into her panties, she brought her hands up. The inside of her panties were a sopping mess, his semen leaking out of her, her own juices overflowing enough to make a shine on her stomach. He pushed two fingers inside her, then three, thrusting them in and out and watching her face. It was what she wanted, and now her stomach tucked in and her ribs pressed out against her skin. God, she was so beautiful.

“Get me off, Josh, please, oh, get me off . . .”

Her face twisted from side to side, her pony tail tangling; she folded both forearms over her face, scissored them tight on either side of her head, hiding her face away, gasping and crying soft mewling sounds.

She bucked when she came, jumping in the bed, one leg shooting out straight.

“Take off these things . . . these garters,” he said, talking quick and desperate.

She heaved breath, eyes fluttering open, looking around the room. He still fingered her.

Kimmy thumbed open the clasps that held her stockings, and he got on his knees, began yanking her panties down her legs. He got them off and

collapsed on top of her. She closed her legs on his waist. His cock was just as hard as when they began.

“Yes,” she said, “yes, put it in, God, I need it . . .”

Her legs tightened around him as he hip-guided the point of his erection into her hungry opening. He went in with no resistance, and her pussy squelched with his entry.

His eyes searched for hers, but Kimmy hid them. More hungry than he’d ever seen her, she was wild with passion. She came again. And though he was between her legs, over top of her, Kimmy didn’t seem connected. Arms over her face, it was like her mind had gone elsewhere while her husband fucked her. He kissed her gasping mouth.

“Deeper,” she urged him again, “you feel so good, I want it . . .”

Say it, Kimmy. Deeper.

But if she was thinking of Devlin, he couldn’t give her what she fantasized. And, fuck, if she’d slept with Devlin who had fifty more pounds of muscle and way more cock, could her Josh ever satisfy his own wife sexually ever again? What an awful thrill . . .

Kimmy came again, face still hidden, but that pouting mouth making small gasps as he thought she orgasmed. Now she hugged arms around him, hiding her face in his collar and clutching his back, wanting more and more and more . . .

His own balls began their boiling over now, convincing himself his wife was thinking of another man while her husband made love to her.

And something dark in him ached to tell her, ached for her to know what he feared: You’re thinking of Devlin, Kimmy, I know it! I can see it on your face, hear it in your cries, feel it in the way your nails run my back. Your mind is elsewhere, it’s with another man . . .

Sex Smell

In the burbling whoosh of the flushed toilet, he dried his penis and testicles with a hand towel that was ready for the wash, anyway. Two times in a row, not too shabby. Two times to completion. Not too shabby at all, indeed.

He chuckled to himself, proud, and also still aroused. But hungry. Way hungry. Before he tossed the towel in the hamper, he paused, plumbing still hissing, sneaking a look over his shoulder. He hadn't fully closed the bathroom door, but he could see movement on the bed, Kimmy still there. Now he frowned, pinched his inner cheek lining between his canines. Tossed another look over his shoulder back to the hamper . . .

No, his wife didn't have sex with Devlin today. That was crazy.

Yeah, he was pretty sure though that Kimmy's wildcat prowess tonight was provoked somehow by Devlin's stroking hand getting her purring. Not touching her, Kimmy wouldn't allow it. But just proximity, maybe.

Devlin was unpalatable. Kimmy didn't like him. Not many people did. At least, not truly. Kissed his ass for what he might offer. But then there was still the issue of Kimmy's restricted behavior at the Monkey House.

A little sliver embedded in Josh's psyche. It told him one more possibility: Kimmy wasn't wearing panties. That's why she'd flinched. That's why she was anxious. That's why she wouldn't easily commit to a play session on the trampoline with her favorite niece Sophie . . .

Outlandish, he knew it. But still, he backed his way to the hamper, eyes on that sliver of open-door, making sure he wouldn't be spotted for what he was about to do.

He tossed the hand towel onto the top, dipped, peeked inside. Kimmy's bra was there. The one she would've worn today. He pushed it aside with his fingers, and underneath there were a pair of panties. Of course—he was being ridiculous. Why was it so much fun for him to poke and prod at this idea of his wife's infidelity? What on earth about that would be arousing? Yet it was.

The panties were rolled into a figure-eight, and he shook them loose, took another careful glance over his shoulder before holding them up near his face. They smelled clean. They smelled like detergent.

Jesus, he was going to have to stop this.

Do you think Kimmy somehow moistened her panties so badly being with Devlin all day she had to throw them out? And then when she suspected you, Detective Columbo, might snoop in the hamper, she tossed a clean pair in there? That's what you really think? . . .

He tossed the panties back in the hamper, on the verge of self-disgust. Pathetic. Poking through the hamper looking for her underwear. Fucking smelling it. Pervert level antics. He stepped away . . . stepped back. Plucked the bra from underneath the panties and returned them over top the way he'd found them. Interesting, though, that the panties didn't match the bra. Would Kimmy mismatch her underwear? Maybe—what did he know? . . .

From the bathroom cupboard, he plucked two hand towels. Fresh one for the bathroom, a fresh one for his wife. Put legs through pajama pants, shrugged on a T-shirt, came out to the bedroom to find Kimmy still in bed with the sheets pulled over herself, a triangle sail of bed sheet crossing from knees to chest, stocking feet stuck out below, her pretty face in a frame of bunched up kimono on the pillow. She said, "What took you so long?"

"I had to pee," he said.

Kimmy held out a hand for the towel.

“Sorry,” he said, and they both laughed. How would he like it, someone dumping two loads inside him and leaving him in the bed to wait for cleanup? “I did—I really had to pee.”

She worked under the sheets, face going through a range of expressions, hands moving below as she wiped herself. Then she tossed out from under the sheet her panties—obviously soiled with his semen. He didn’t mention it, picked them up, grabbing her high heel shoes as well, going to the closet and filing away her footwear then putting her dirtied panties in the bathroom hamper.

When he came out, she was still wiping. He said, “I want to grab that food. You stay in bed. I’ll bring it in, we can watch something on the laptop.”

She sat up, one hand with the towel pressed under the sheets between her legs, the other knocking her ponytail over her shoulder then straightening the kimono. “I think I’ll come out.”

“Whatever you like,” he said, “I’m going to get the food heated.”

In the kitchen, he opened their paper bag from Good Taste, touched container tops to find them still pretty warm. But when he plated their wing combos, he figured they should both go in the microwave, one plate at a time.

His was ready, hers in the microwave, when Kimmy emerged from the bedroom. He was saddened to see her in an oversized shirt. He showed her with an expression, then leaned over the island counter pass-through to see her feet in fuzzy slippers. He reached across, plucked up the bottom of her T-shirt to reveal cotton pajama shorts. “Can’t say I’m not disappointed,” he said.

She came around into the kitchen saying, “You want me to eat chicken wings wearing lingerie?” She thumbed the microwave door button, and it swung open with a cloud of steam.

“You know,” he said, picking up his plate, “I have to admit, it’s kind of a fantasy.”

Her plate was too hot, and she set it down on the counter, wagging her hands like she'd burned them. She sucked one of her fingers, said, "I will put it back on if you want . . ."

"Would you?"

"I kinda feel good in it. You want me to? . . ."

"Are you serious?"

"No . . . Well, kind of. I'd rather sit in pajamas if I'm eating wings, but . . ."

"Let's just eat," he said, thinking how you could take something too far. What was he going to do, sit and watch TV with Kimmy in her lingerie, making her perform for him while he ate dinner?

They brought their plates into the family room and turned on the television. Instead of sitting on the couch, they sat with their butts on the floor, their backs against the couch's front face. He said, "You didn't get a drink?"

Kimmy was untying her ponytail, re-tying it tighter. She said, "Do we have any wine?"

"You want a glass of wine?"

"I feel like a glass of wine."

No further prompt, he jumped up and went to the kitchen, poured his wife a glass of red, feeling good now, grabbing himself a bottle of beer. Returned to Kimmy flicking through channels. He said, "Put on that Jenguk High, or whatever, that Korean show."

"You don't watch that."

"You can show it to me."

"Nah, it's too much to explain. And, seriously, you're not going to get it."

"What— Korean culture's so different from mine, but—"

“It’s kind of for girls, Josh. Teenage girls.”

“I’m not unlike a Korean girl.”

She nudged him with her knee for being silly, face still turned to the television, changing channels with the remote. Light flickered on her beautiful face, and he watched the muscles of her jaw flex as she chewed. Even like this, she was incredibly sexy, even wiping grease from her plump lips with the back of her hand. Absent-minded, not even aware of the effect she had on the guy sitting right next to her. Had she always been this hot? Stupid, because of course she was. But there was something different about her he couldn’t put his finger on. It was like you knew somebody for a long time, and they went and lost fifteen pounds and worked out, and all of a sudden you could see the angle of their jaw, or maybe the grace of their neck, something about the way their cheeks had sunk made them look suddenly sexy. Alluring. Kimmy had always worked out. Was always thin. What was it about her appearance that seemed so changed?

She couldn’t decide what to watch so she left it on the news, setting the remote down now, picking up a chicken wing in two hands and gnawing away the flesh. He joined in.

Without prompting—like it had been on her mind—out of the blue she offered up an explanation. She said, “I just didn’t feel clean.”

“What do you mean?”

She thumbed over her shoulder, wiped her mouth. “When we got in. I’d been sitting in a car all day long. I had to walk around the port out in Hamilton. It was hot today. I just didn’t feel clean. I was in and out of all these buildings, it’s the port, you know?” She shrugged, met his eyes. Then: “Here,” she said, taking her ponytail and smelling it. She leaned forward and presented the ponytail to him. “Do you smell chemicals? Fertilizer?”

“Fertilizer?” He leaned forward and smelled her hair. He told her he didn’t smell fertilizer.

She smiled again, then offered it once more, giving him a curious look. He leaned closer, smelled again. “No,” he told her. “I think I smell shampoo.”

She said, “You’re sure you don’t smell anything?” She scrutinized him with a strange expression, smiling lopsided, eyes narrowed.

He smirked, eyed her slyly in return. “You know what—maybe sweat. Maybe sex smell . . .”

She clucked her tongue and laughed, pushed him away with a hand. “Don’t, Josh, don’t embarrass me . . .”

“I don’t know what to tell you,” he laughed. “I don’t smell fertilizer.”

She shrugged again, saying, “I just thought I’d change and I . . . wanted a shower.”

“I don’t care,” he told her. “Clean, dirty—you know I’m not fussy.”

“No. But I am.”

“It was unexpected.”

“It was,” she agreed, starting in on a new chicken wing. “I’m so hungry,” she said, chewing on one side, rolling her eyes up, covering her lips with a hand while she spoke.

They were quiet, eating and watching news, but after a while, he couldn’t let it go unmentioned. “How was it?—this was your first day with Devlin? . . .”

She nodded, scrunched up the paper towel he brought, wiped her lips. She set down the chicken bone and wiped her fingers. “Yeah. I hardly see him, but today I spent all day with him.”

“You made it home in one piece.”

She made a funny face, like he wasn’t far off the mark.

“Did he say anything annoying today or was he bearable?”

“Bearable,” she said. “You know, to be honest, at work he’s really just about business.”

“Yeah, I guess. He likes to kick his shoes off and be an asshole on the weekends, though.” They both laughed, Kimmy hard enough she had to take a sip of the wine.

“Yeah. Maybe,” she said, “I don’t think you’re wrong.”

“What was in Hamilton?”

“We had to go out and meet some guy looking to set up a contract. Chinese guy. He had me to translate for the guy’s translator.”

“Talk about redundancy.”

She agreed, hmm’d, said, “He was looking for subtext.”

“And you gave him subtext?”

“I think so. I mean, my Chinese is not too bad, but still . . .”

“I have faith in you.”

“Thank you,” she said, reached over and squeezed his wrist.

He put his hand over hers. “I really do.”

“Good. I think Devlin does too. I think I did a good job for him today.”

“It’s a long way out to Hamilton. Long way back again. What did you guys talk about? You went in the same car?”

“Yeah. He drove.”

“That roadster?”

“The Mercedes? Yes. We drove to Hamilton, and I don’t know . . . we talked about whatever . . .”

“What’s his car like?”

“It’s nice, Josh—I don’t know what to say. I’m not really into cars.”

“Leather seats and everything . . .”

“Oh yeah, no, it’s really nice. And fast . . .”

“Was he speeding?”

“It didn’t feel like it, but, yeah, he probably was.”

“And what did you guys talk about?”

“I told you. Whatever.”

“Did you talk about me?”

She looked at him long and steady, trying to assess his meaning. He didn’t even know his meaning. He could tell she was chewing the inside of her cheek. She said, “I didn’t talk about you.”

He asked why not, though he wasn’t sure whether it was good or bad she hadn’t talked about him.

“You tell me. I feel like I don’t want to talk about stuff you don’t want to talk about . . .”

“With Devlin?”

“Yeah, you know. Maybe it’s like you don’t exist.”

It troubled him, and he searched for brighter meaning in her words, saying, “But I exist, Kimmy.”

“Oh Josh,” she said laughing, leaning away before swaying back. “You definitely exist.” She shrugged, looking up saying, “To me you exist. I just don’t want . . .”

“What—you think he’ll . . . what?”

“Josh, you don’t like him.”

He frowned, watching her. “You don’t think he likes me.”

“I don’t know. I just didn’t think I should talk about you. But out of respect for you, if you know what I mean.”

“But he knows you’re married to me . . .”

She gave him a puzzled look, one bordering on disgust. She lifted her hand and showed him her wedding ring. “He knows I’m married, Josh.”

“To me,” he said.

“Josh, he knows I’m married to you,” she said chuckling.

“I know—I know he knows. It’s just . . .” His hand fell in his lap, and he shook his head.

Kimmy studied him, and he waved her away because he didn’t want her looking at him. His hand moved, his thumb bumping against his renewed erection. Just sitting here talking to his wife about how she sat next to his high school bully today—all day—in his expensive car got him rock hard again.

He said, “I don’t think I want to talk about Devlin anymore.”

“Fine by me,” she said, in a melody, like he couldn’t have spoke truer words.

She pushed the remote over to his side, picked up a fresh wing in two hands saying, “You find us something to watch . . .”

III

Friday, August 7

Demons

For two days, all he could think about was Kimmy with Devlin. Only, in the aftermath of a great night of sex with Kimmy, his head was clearer. Now it wasn't because thinking of them together clicked a funny dark spot in his sexuality he didn't even like being there, it was the truth of Devlin's nature that reminded him to worry.

Kimmy didn't know how low Devlin could go. She knew he was an asshole. Devlin'd been rude and dismissive with her—shit, she'd tried to hit him and that was how this all began.

And that was what made him finally blurt it out, unprepared and frustrated, first thing on a Friday morning: "I don't like you working there."

And it was Kimmy who'd prompted this statement, going on while they jostled for position in the kitchen, both of them making their own breakfast, Kimmy outlining her day and how she was going to impress Devlin.

Who fucking cares about Devlin, he was thinking, waiting for his toast to pop. And he just came out and said it: "I don't like you working there."

Now Kimmy was looking over her shoulder at him with a puzzled expression. She said, "What? . . ."

"You already know that," he said.

She resumed frying an egg, saying toward the stove, "Where's this coming from now?"

"Now? I don't know . . ." Wishing he hadn't brought it up.

“Tell me,” she said, still facing away.

“I guess . . . hearing you talk about him at home.”

“I’m not talking about him. I’m talking about how I have to solve this problem he—”

“Yeah, to impress him,” he said.

“I want to be good at my job, Josh.”

“I don’t doubt you’ll be awesome at your job, that’s not what I’m saying.”

Now it was him looking over his shoulder, watching his wife’s back as she turned off the stove, rested her hands on the counter’s edge.

He said, “What?” Thinking she might be mad at him.

“You don’t like me working there?”

“Does it surprise you? I mean— Can you turn around, please?”

Kimmy did, leaning her ass on the counter and folding her arms.

He said, “You know I don’t like it.”

“You didn’t stop me.”

And though he shouldn’t have said it, he did. “I guess I hoped I wouldn’t have to.”

Kimmy scoffed. “Really? Are you trying to make me feel guilty? Josh, I’m already working there, what do you want me to do now?”

His toast popped, and he sighed, rubbed his forehead. “Nothing. I . . . I don’t know. I’m not saying don’t work there.”

“Why wouldn’t you have expressed to me the tiniest doubt before?”

“How could you not know it existed? You know what I think about Devlin.”

“We talked about that. You never said—”

“I’d never tell you not to work for him.”

Kimmy exhaled slowly, cheeks puffed out. “God, Josh, I don’t know what to think about this.”

“I don’t know what to tell you either.”

She said, “Before I ever worked there, we sat down. We talked about it. You told me—”

“I didn’t tell you not to.”

Her eyebrows went up. “But you wanted to tell me not to?”

Probably. “No, that’s not it either.”

“What, then? Where does that leave us, Josh? Leaves us right where we are. I’m already working there. I can’t change that now. We did talk about it—we talked about me taking this job, what it meant . . .”

“I know, I know,” he said. “Look, I don’t know what to tell you. We talked about it. We said in three years time it would be like you’d worked almost a decade at immigration. Three years time, we bank that money, we live off my salary. It seems simple, I know. The pragmatic side of me—”

“We’re both pragmatic, Josh, we decided together.”

“Kimmy—I see the sense in it. I get it. Three years and then where will we be?”

“So what’s the problem? What’s different?”

“It’s having to hear about Devlin. Having to hear about you being in the car with him all day, driving around in his fancy car . . .”

Her features scrunched. “What on earth does that mean?—It sounds jealous . . . it sounds like you’re implying something . . .”

“It’s not that, Kimmy . . .”

Point blank, looking right at him, she said it: “You don’t trust me?”

He shook his head no. “I don’t trust Devlin.”

She frowned, looked aside, and then the frown deepened. “This is crazy.”

He shrugged, tried to show her she was making a bigger deal out of it than he intended. “Okay, Kimmy, I’m just bothered. I’ll get over it,” he said. “It was hard to take, knowing that you were in the car with him all day long. All the way out to Hamilton, driving all the way back again . . . I try to be strong about it, I don’t want to burden you. I’m just having a weak moment right now. You’re telling me about how you’re going to impress him by solving this problem at work. I’m about to start my day and I’ve already got the name Devlin in my ear.”

“Do you not want me to tell you what’s going on at work?”

“Maybe.”

“I can do that if you want, Josh.”

“I don’t know if that’s what I want or not. I guess we’re just going to have to feel our way through this.”

“If we stay on the same page, we’ll be fine.”

And that was the truth. Boy, was that the truth.

But he hadn’t been truthful with her. He didn’t even know what the hell he’d been doing, but whatever it was, it wasn’t truthful. The subterfuge, trying to act like a family guy, getting his wife to see him with Sophie . . . a little girl that could look like their little girl. How cheap. But what was he going to do?

Maybe put your foot in the water. He drew a deep inhale, wishing he had more time to prepare, but wanting to test how he might sound when he was honest, even when honesty was upsetting.

“You know, Kimmy, Devlin . . . made my life miserable.”

She nodded, looking at the floor between them. “He made a lot of people’s lives miserable.”

“I only care about what he did to me, right now. It was all more than ten years ago, but now you work for him and I can’t stop thinking about . . . the things he did to me.”

“He bullied you.”

“Boy, did he ever, Kimmy.”

Now she could see his point better, and the stiffness left her. She’d had walls up, looking to get feisty with him, but now she knew she couldn’t. She slumped, her crossed arms fell to her sides. “Yeah, okay. I hear you.” She came across the kitchen space to him, slow, smiling. Her arms circled his waist, and she leaned against him. He held her.

He said, “It’s not just bullying, Kimmy. It was bad.”

She stepped back. “Did he ever hurt you?”

Staying strong, he said: “Sure.”

“He beat you up?”

“He was rough. They hurt me, him and his friends. Changed who I am as a person, that’s for sure. Hurt me physically, hurt me emotionally . . .”

“You never said anything. I mean, you alluded to it, but I didn’t know what it was like.”

“It was bad. Like, you asked if he ever beat me up . . .? Here’s one. Do you remember a guy named Johnny Rumble?”

“No . . .”

“Went to elementary school with him and then high school. For a few years. He was there Grade 9 and 10, one of Devlin’s buddies. They played hockey together. Johnny Rumble was a fucking psycho. And that guy loved Devlin. So, one time . . .”

And now he wondered how to continue.

Kimmy said, “Go on, tell me. I’m listening.” She showed him a soft expression and honest eyes.

“It was . . . this one was Grade 9. It was after a school dance and I was with some of my friends. We were just walking through the neighborhood, you know Soap Street, down toward the old village from the school where they used to do the winter carnival . . .?”

“Yeah, I know . . .”

“I’m just walking along there, but it’s raining, no—misting—and I’ve got my hood up, but me and the guys I’m with, we hear these footsteps coming. But like coming fast. We turn around and it’s Johnny Rumble. He just walks right up to us, then he like points over his shoulder saying Devlin wants your coat. And I go like What? I don’t understand. He . . . punched me in the stomach so hard. I didn’t even see it coming, and . . .”

Kimmy looked uncomfortable, moved again to hold him.

“Anyway. That’s just a little taste. That’s just one day of my life with Devlin. There are others. He didn’t hit me, I know . . . But if you want to know what it was like, there it was. Devlin didn’t have a jacket, and he was hanging around with his psycho buddy Johnny Rumble. He tells Johnny Go get my jacket, Johnny does. That guy hit me so hard I couldn’t breathe. I was laying there, and the guy . . . I guess robs me. You’re a lawyer; it’s theft. Theft by strong-arm or whatever you might want to call it. Bullying sure, you can call it bullying. But sometimes bullying is more than just the word ‘bullying.’ Sometimes it’s legitimately criminal.”

“I’m sorry, Josh,” she whispered, and he hated to hear it. Now he felt weak again. A fourteen-year-old event retold to his wife, and he felt as powerless and humiliated as he had that night.

He exhaled, pinched the bridge of his nose, regretting even telling her that. He said, “Well, anyway, Devlin got my jacket.”

The worst thing was there was way more to the story of Johnny Rumble than what he told Kimmy.

Look at this, trying to be honest and he couldn’t even commit. What had really happened? Everything was true, but once again, here he was trying to be honest, and what he’d delivered was hollow.

He’d been with Rich Bridge and Kimmy’s later high school friend, Karina. Back then, in the first year of high school, Karina had been a girl he had a deep and hurting crush on. The three of them’d been walking Karina home after the dance. He’d danced with Karina that night to a slow song. It had felt like they’d danced as friends, but there was a spark inside him—maybe there was more . . . Man, was he ever on cloud nine.

They were all walking arm-in-arm. And it was true, footsteps from behind had him turning around to see Johnny Rumble standing there. The visage of this guy instantly threw a spike of dread in his heart. Left behind a year (shit, maybe two), while he was in the same grade as him and Rich and Karina, Johnny was older. And his presence could only mean one thing.

Kimmy didn’t remember Johnny because he’d been expelled later that year. They sent Johnny to trade school. The guy even had a chance at one point to succeed in hockey, but he threw it all away because all the guy did was fight.

So here he is, a fourteen-year-old Josh turning around to see this guy, probably fifteen-years-old, but not like any other fifteen-year-old he ever saw. The guy had lines on his face like a grown up. Six feet tall, maybe two hundred pounds, spiky blond hair . . .

Johnny Rumble'd said, "It's raining, Devlin needs your jacket." But it didn't end there. No, there were lots of homophobic epithets cast Josh's way right in front of Karina. That was common. It was a long winding thread of his past with Devlin. Something he didn't want to get into with Kimmy. So he'd left that part out.

But there he was: Johnny Rumble humiliating him in front of Karina Brubaker. And what's Josh going to do? Stand up to this nut-job? No way. So he begins to say something . . . and like he told Kimmy: One wicked punch, didn't even see it coming. An uppercut into his stomach. It literally felt like his organs had pushed up inside his rib cage. The air shot out of his lungs. He threw up. Threw up and then almost aspirated his vomit, gagging for air. Crumpled at Karina's feet. What does Rich do? Nothing. Stands there holding onto Karina, the two of them looking down at this pathetic heap at their feet. Johnny Rumble'd then pulled his jacket over his head like it's a hockey fight. More humiliation? . . .

How about that, Kimmy, want to hear some more degradation? . . . Rumble kicked me in the face. Kicked me in the stomach, trying to get the jacket off, pulling it but my arms were cinched down at my sides trying to hold my guts in. So to loosen my arms up he just kicked me in the neck, in the face, the mouth . . . Then, the psycho getting off on it, gets the jacket he wanted, and that's not enough. Wants my wallet, too. He's all charged up, pulling me up by my pants, lifting me by my legs, then my pants coming down . . . guy grabs my wallet, takes out ten dollars, chucks the wallet in the bushes. Takes off, leaving me curled up with my ass showing, bringing my knees up so no one would see my junk . . .

He could still feel the misty cold rain on the small of his bare back and buttocks. Then Rich was pulling at his arm to get him to roll over. Both of them, Rich and Karina, crouching down, looking across the street. Devlin shrugging his arms into Josh's stolen jacket. The jacket too small, Johnny Rumble and two other guys all laughing, Devlin standing there putting his arms out straight showing how the jacket was too small. Then trying to rip it by flexing his muscles, everybody thinking it was fucking hilarious.

That was the night any hope he had of being with Karina Brubaker was lost, his last real crush-hopeful image of her in his mind's eye was blonde-haired

Karina kneeling over, not looking at him but looking across the street at the antics of shithead Devlin Stone monkeying around in Josh's jacket while she rubbed circles on Josh's chest trying to help him loosen up and breathe again, saying softly, "It's okay, Josh, just breathe, just breathe . . ."



Across from her was a plastic stand divided in a grid of wire boxes that held pamphlets, brochures and rack cards. The titles like "Understanding Your Customs Tariffs Obligations;" "Goods Processing And The Courier Low Value Shipment Program;" "Marine Container Examination: What To Expect . . ."

On her right sat a nervous looking Chinese man in a shiny and uncomfortable suit whose pants were too short. On her right, an Indian woman, maybe Pakistani. She held a briefcase on her bright-colored sari lap, the kind with locks operated by four-digit combination dials.

She was in a typical Canadian Bureaucracy Waiting Room in a fancy downtown building—Number One, Front Street. The waiting room table held assorted magazines. Some involved the trade, some were Maclean's, Outdoor Life, even a Harrowsmith—harkening back to the weekend that began this whole journey. Tiffany's cottage in the sleepy town of Harrowsmith. She rolled her eyes, checked her watch. Now her knees were jumping. She brought her satchel up and lay it in her lap.

That was a heavy load Josh lay on her this morning. But she'd asked for it. What did she expect? She knew Josh hated Devlin. And knew Devlin had nothing but low-level disdain for her husband. Couldn't she see that Josh had been bullied? It all made sense. It was more than the obvious fact Devlin Stone was an asshole. Maybe in the back of her mind she always knew it, but she hadn't anticipated what Josh told her.

Poor Josh, sweet Josh. Could picture him from back then. They'd shared a kiss end of the year in Grade 11 before she went to visit her family in Taiwan for the summer. Kissed a boy she had a crush on. Josh Waters. Could picture him now, that young guy with that fresh face and cute smile. Skinny, unassuming, but honest and caring. Smart, too. A really good guy. One she stayed in touch with. Even though when she returned from Taiwan their romance (or whatever it had been) had fizzled, they still spent a lot of time together. Their love simmered on the back burner for three more years.

It was awful to think of her husband the way he'd described. Awful to think of a good guy like Josh Waters laid out on the sidewalk. No recollection of who this Johnny Rumble was, but could picture some hockey playing thug just the way Josh had described, some guy twice Josh's size, half his brainpower, dumb, reptilian eyes . . . And just like Josh said, Devlin wants his jacket, this bigger kid punching Josh in the stomach to get it.

She winced now at the mental image of the man she loved buckled over on some other guy's fist, made a slight hiss that got some of the others in the Border Services waiting room turning her way. She checked her watch again.

Poor Josh and his buddies. No match for guys like Devlin and his friends. They were just prey. And she could sympathize. Girls wouldn't send somebody to punch you in the stomach, but they had other ways to devastate you. Eviscerate you with words, hair tosses, rumors and innuendo. Dismissiveness.

All of it was a long time ago. She doubted Devlin was a man who sent his friends to go grab a jacket these days. And in the end, Devlin hadn't punched Josh. Josh claimed Devlin had sent Johnny Rumble, going only by Johnny Rumble's words. Devlin wants your jacket. Josh hates Devlin, blames Devlin.

It wasn't an excuse. She wasn't excusing Devlin's behavior. And Josh was always honest. Honest but hyperbolic. Josh believed Devlin was the one who wanted his jacket. But she knew how boys worked. Johnny Rumble, tough as he may be, was desperate for daddy Devlin's attention because Johnny Rumble didn't get that attention at home. Johnny Rumble sees Josh,

easy prey Josh, Devlin doesn't have a jacket, so his monkey brain connects the dots. Get jacket for boss.

What does she do now, ask Devlin if he ever sent some guy to punch Josh? So weird. What did Josh want from her? Want me to quit, want me to give up this job where I'm making money, doing something I like, bringing us closer to our goal . . . And why? Devlin stole your jacket when you were fourteen? He didn't even steal it.

These were the kinds of things Josh should have brought up before she started at Stone Brokerage. Now she was in. Now it was too late.

A raised voice from afar: "Mrs. Chang?"

Her eyes lifted to the middle-aged woman behind the Plexiglas visor at the service counter. Barely enough energy to raise her chin from her bureaucratic desk. Border Services was the kind of place she was used to from working in immigration, though she'd never been to a Trade Operations office, they were all the same people. Maybe she knew how this game worked after all.

She rose and nodded; another woman appeared at the archway that led to the interior offices. The woman said, "Agent Parker can see you, it's Office Four," pointing down the hall, "fourth door on the right . . ."

IV

Saturday, August 8

Pops

After Mom died, Pop had stayed single for the longest time, all through her university years, and didn't get a female friend until he'd sold his jewelry businesses and moved to Markham. Susan Araki looked thirty-five, so when Pop first introduced the woman to her as "his friend," she'd worried. But Susan was fifty-two, the same age as her dad. Josh was in the kitchen with Susan now, helping her bake, so Kimmy sat at the dining room table with her father sharing a small pot of green tea.

Pop was obsessed with her new job, asking again about the view from her office. She said, "I told you: it's nothing that special." Part of the reason she'd been enticed by the job offer from Devlin (hidden and unsaid but powerful) was the knowledge her father would find some peace in it. Not just peace, but pride. Try explaining to your workaholic father that after six years of university you pick a law firm with humble salary and limited room for advancement. Pop never complained (only insinuated), but her sister told her how he was disappointed. So, for the moment, she'd bask in the glow of his satisfaction. "But, I tell you what," she said to her dad, "give me a month there, come by one day and see it. We'll go out for lunch."

Pop said, "See what that painting looks like on the wall."

It would be great if he'd come, but it wasn't likely—he worked six days a week, often seven. Since selling the three jewelry stores (in Kingston, Gananoque, and Cornwall), he'd opened a new one in Agincourt, and it was as busy now as the other three combined.

Josh came into the dining room ahead of Susan and holding a tray of sugar cookies; Susan trailed, holding a cake pedestal with a small but elaborate

Black Forest. Together, her husband and the woman her father wouldn't admit was his girlfriend arranged the offering on the table on either side of the tea setting. While Susan was born and raised in Japan and the meal she prepared today was traditional—a Hiyashi chūka with ham and egg, and a cold tomato soup to start—she had a passion for Western-style baking. Josh always got excited coming to see Pop and Susan, just to see what the woman baked next.

She said to Susan, “Is this where Josh takes credit for making dessert?”

“I'll have you know,” Josh said, “I put these cookies in the oven all by myself. Where would we be without me?”

Susan patted his arm. She liked Josh as much as Josh liked her.

Pop said to Josh, “Have you been to her new office?”

“Not invited,” Josh said, with charm for her father's sake, who had no idea of Josh's past with her new boss.

“You be a good boy, maybe she change her mind,” Pop said, grabbing and shaking Josh's upper arm then laughing. She looked in Josh's eyes, trying to command him: Don't bring it up. It's not my father's business.

Susan returned to the kitchen and refilled the kettle. Pop asked Josh how he was doing at Swanson. Her phone dinged in her purse slung over the back of her chair, and with Josh and Pop talking and Susan away from the table, she took the opportunity to check her messages. It was the second message coming in since they'd been in Pop's condo.

It was a text from Devlin asking her what she did on Saturdays that had her away from her phone since she couldn't answer his first message. She texted him back saying she was having lunch with her dad and what was he doing texting on a Saturday afternoon since she knew he wasn't working. He texted he was at the Rogers Centre with a whiskey waiting for the Jays game to start and wondered how she was doing.

Right—the Jays game. He’d arranged suite seats standing outside the cargo container while she’d cleaned herself with his kerchief because he’d fingered her so well her orgasm had her squirting all over her legs. She hadn’t seen or talked directly to him since driving back from Hamilton and couldn’t help wondering if he’d be manipulative enough to coincide his text to her as a reminiscence. He knew she knew he’d booked Jays tickets because she chastised him for it back in the Mercedes, mad at his indifference in the cargo container. Which was stupid—what did she expect, he’d stay with her and help her clean her mess?

“Sounds like you’re both doing well,” her father said to Josh. “Two future vice-presidents.” Now Pop held up his tea cup, and the others joined in. She swapped the phone to her other hand and raised her tea cup as well.

Josh sipped tea, looked to her and said quietly, “Should you be doing that at the table?” Meaning her phone.

She said, “It’s work,” for her father’s ears so she wouldn’t get in trouble.

Pop said to Josh, “Let her—it’s okay,” patting Josh’s forearm. “She has to make good impression, let them know she work hard. I forgive her today.” Now Pop smiled her way.

She smiled in return, said, “I should take this,” wagging the phone at them.

Pop excused her, but Josh made a mild expression of exasperation. But now he and her Pop would be in their glory, planning grand-babies together. Her sister hadn’t done it yet, either, and her Pop was probably ready to explode. He’d taken the failed pregnancy as bad as she did.

She stepped away from the table, walked toward the living room and stood by the windows that looked out over the industrial park stretch of Markham, a swath of green where the Rouge would run.

She texted.

Kimmy: trying to annoy me, sending a message from the Jays game?

Devlin: you still sore?

She chuckled.

Kimmy: I know your games

Devlin: You only think you do

Kimmy: you're admitting this isn't about work?

There was a long moment before he returned a message. She watched cars sliding along left and right on the 407, beyond the green-space, sun winking off their hump shapes. Her phone dinged.

Devlin: how we doing on the paperwork for Chow? We good?

Kimmy: all good

Devlin: how about the other thing? am I going to have to fire you?

Kimmy: I'm working on it

Devlin: that's good. enough business. I need you on Monday night

Another sly chuckle, she put her gold pendant in her mouth, zipped her necklace chain back and forth through its loop; texted.

Kimmy: and... what do you need me for?

Devlin: first, get your mind out of the gutter

Kimmy: my mind is nowhere near the gutter. my mind is squeaky clean

Now she glanced to the table, saw that Josh was embroiled in close conversation with her Pop and Susan, and she stepped further away, deeper into Pop's living room where he kept all his furniture spotless and gleaming like no one had ever sat in here before.

Devlin: so if I asked for a picture of your cooch I probably won't get one?

Kimmy: not a chance

Devlin: saves me asking I guess. good thing I already have one

Now she was full-on smiling, chain in her mouth, running the pendant up and down the links, making it zip and vibrate against her pressed lips. A glance over her shoulder showed her family still talking, drinking tea, and eating cake. She went to the divan, an ebony monster with Chinoiserie fabric, turned and sat down but kept her face lowered to her phone.

Kimmy: feel free to send me a picture of that dick

She covered her own mouth, not even believing she actually texted that. But, shit, it was a Saturday, and this definitely wasn't a work related matter. This was just two people talking, and it had nothing to do with her job.

She fanned her own face, trying not to break out laughing. She waited for an answer, secretly hoping that an image would pop up. But it didn't, just another text.

Devlin: don't think your phone has enough storage

Kimmy: that's not how phones work

Devlin: oh okay then hold on

Kimmy: don't you dare!

Devlin: you want it or not?

She chewed her lip; her cheeks dimpled—she could feel them dimpled—chewing her lower lip and trying not to burst out laughing, trying not even to smile. What would Josh think, turning around and seeing her on the phone yet again dealing with Devlin? And smiling? He was already mad. She got up again, went near the window and leaned an elbow on the ledge, texting in return.

Kimmy: go ahead if you want, it's your phone

Devlin: I'm afraid I can't whip it out here I'm sitting in the suite

Kimmy: don't worry about it then another time

Devlin: hang tight

What did she think she was doing? Why would she be texting with Devlin like this? First of all, why would she be doing it at all? Second, why would she be doing it when she was having lunch with her dad? Using this opportunity to flirt with her boss while her husband was probably chatting about their future . . . Well, that was probably exactly why. Let them plan

for the future, let her deal with the present. The present was about doing this thing. Finally doing it. Getting it over with.

And enjoying it, because you know you're going to enjoy it, don't act like you're not.

That was the thing, dealing with Devlin got her heart racing. More and more, just being around him had her only thinking about sex. Even now she could feel the heat at her core. Her stomach was warm, and it had nothing to do with the green tea. No, it was all about Devlin. Her husband's bully, of all people. The man who'd maybe sent some other dude across the street to punch Joshy in the stomach and get his jacket from him. The one who'd maybe left her husband with an emotional scar, probably crying in the rain. What a shitty person she was. What a shitty person Devlin was, too. One time was all it would be . . .

Her phone dinged.

Devlin: you sure you're up for this?

Kimmy: I've cleared off all my phones hard drive. Lots of room for a picture of your giant dick

Devlin: you got me wanting to leave the game. Where are you?

Kimmy: told you. I'm at my pops place

Devlin: you texting me from your pops?

Kimmy: you texted me. I'm answering.

Devlin: I was just messing around, now I'm seriously getting the fuck out of the Jays game. Meet me somewhere

Kimmy: can't. I'm in Markham. Enjoy your game

Devlin: here. picture for you. One from the archives, a classic...

Shit. He'd really sent a picture. She glanced over at Josh—still in close conversation with her dad. Josh talking with his hands, low to the table, telling them about what? Plans for their future? Assuring her father the babies were on the way? Pop had babies on the brain . . .

She pivoted, walked away to where no one could see her, walking out of the view from the dining room, deeper into the living room, stepping down into the family room and standing by dad's big screen TV.

She touched the thumbnail image, already seeing in its small size a man standing with no clothes, and even at that tiny picture size could see the scale of his penis compared to his legs. And holy shit, there it was. A real live picture just for her. Or, more accurately, probably for plenty of girls. As he'd said, it was a classic, one from the archives. Probably one of his favorite dick pictures that he loved to send to girls. But at least he'd sent it to her.

Good Lord, was it incredible. She'd touched that huge penis. Put her hands on that man's hard and muscular body. And look at him . . . Standing across from a mirror, phone held up, handsome face studying his phone's screen

while he clicked the picture. Probably'd just worked out. God, she could even imagine a guy like Devlin might've gone to work out specifically to get pumped up for a good dick picture. It was worth it.

Muscles stood out all over, shoulders bulging, his chest a hard slab completely delineated from the swoop of his lats and narrow stomach. Hair on his chest, down his abdomen, pointing to his bellybutton. He had stomach muscles, and he was flexing them. Vain, but she didn't care because he looked so fucking hot. And his dick . . . Legitimately halfway down his thigh. Enormous. How could he wear pants? But it wasn't upright and erect and ready to be pushed up inside her body (even though it was covered with her saliva and semen). Some of the girls who'd received this picture maybe never got to sleep with him. Never got to see his dick all the way hard. Never got to feel his big hands on them. But she had. Believe it or not, Kimmy Chang had been with Devlin Stone.

Not all the way, but it was only a matter of time . . .

Kimmy: I love it

Devlin: how about another coochie pic now?

Kimmy: in your dreams

She laughed out loud, then covered her mouth. Opened up the picture again, studied Devlin's incredible naked body. Went back to the text.

Kimmy: what's Monday? But I warn you my mind is fully in the gutter now

Devlin: you put it there. I need you for work on Monday.

Kimmy: shoot

Devlin: don't worry, it's drinks. Drinks with a couple of people I want you to meet, potential clients.

Kimmy: Chinese?

Devlin: no. Believe it or not I need you for more things than the languages you speak

Kimmy: pretty face?

Devlin: now you get it

She laughed again, feeling more comfortable talking with Devlin where no one could see her.

Kimmy: what's it about?

Devlin: drinks at the bar at the Royal York. After work.

Drinks. After work. At night. At a hotel. And after drinks? . . .

Kimmy: I'll be there

Sext

It was driving him crazy to watch her so separate from them. And one look at her expression would tell you whatever it was she was doing didn't have to do with work. The way she'd playfully run her necklace through her mouth. The way she would flick at the dangling pendant. Put the pendant in her mouth. And she was smiling. Any work text he ever got did not put a smile on his face. It was almost guaranteed she was talking to Devlin. She hadn't made friends there. Who was that one who was her secretary—Tami? She wasn't friends with Tami. Tami wouldn't be making her laugh. It was Devlin. Devlin was the one she spent time with. So if this was a work text, and she was smiling, it was with Devlin.

And this was after he told her just a small slice of Devlin Stone's meanness.

A month ago, before the reunion had ever happened, if you'd asked Kimmy what she thought of Devlin Stone, she'd say he was a turd. If she was feeling particularly feisty, she would say he was a piece of shit. But in the last month, all sorts of profanity came out of her mouth. She said shit all the time now. He'd heard her say fuck. That wasn't Kimmy . . .

And now she was working for him. Now she was working for Devlin Stone. She'd got in a fight with the guy at the reunion, got mad at him for being the prick he usually was, and they fought. Devlin pushed her down on the grass and got between her legs. Kimmy said he was hard. And now she was working for him . . .?

You're so fucking blind, Josh.

Blind to the fact that he'd wanted this in some way.

You let Kimmy get close to Devlin because for some reason it'd hurt in a way you hate that you craved.

But now he didn't. Not anymore. It was getting too real.

He'd never been the kind of man to stand up to his partner for fear she would think he was some sort of tyrant denying her freedom and will.

And that was why he assumed Kimmy'd always loved him. Because he was the kind of man she wanted. Now was it possible she wanted this kind of man? Look at her. Smiling.

And here with Susan and Simon, both of them honest and hard-working and pure people. Simple wants. Family. Grandchildren. Kimmy came from an excellent home. Sure, her mother had died when she was young, but her dad was a loving father. A hard driver, not somebody you'd want to disappoint, but not a tyrant. And that's how Josh'd tried to be with her. But it didn't get them anywhere. And now he was pumping the brakes, but this thing he'd somehow allowed had so much down force, barreling downhill on a snowy road, brakes locked but the momentum just keeping it plummeting . . .

When he'd told her that little blood blister of psychic hurt from his past, he'd thought it would seal the deal. Kimmy would return to him, come to her senses. It would be like ringing her bell. Snapping her out of the hypnotist's spell.

Or was it possible he was that tyrant and didn't know it? This was jealousy in his heart. Jealousy drove men to harm and retard women for millennia. Was what he was seeing real, or was it his imagination?

What if Devlin's masculine appeal was in your head, and that's not what had Kimmy working for him? Maybe it really was the job. He had to admit, since she'd been to work for the last week, he'd never seen her more energized. That dark swirling fantasy part of him liked to imagine that maybe she was inspired by lust. Maybe some kind of frightening attraction to Devlin Stone. But was Kimmy really like that? She was always tantalized by challenge. Loved to succeed. Put tasks in front of her, she would break

them down into their milestone goals, happily chugging until they were done.

It was a hopeful thought.

That his wife—his sweet and loving and very smart wife—saw through Devlin Stone’s veneer, placated him, humored him by laughing at his jokes . . . Maybe even like now, when they were just texting.

It was the job; it was the work . . . and secretly he knew it was also the reward. She wasn’t always such a money-minded person, but she did like this new compensation.

He stepped down, crossed the family room, Kimmy not seeing him coming, and when he was close and asked her if she would come along with her Pop and Susan, she jumped, pressing the screen to her chest so he wouldn’t see.

That simple action, that defensive jump, told him the bad news. And it was in her eyes, too.

Kimmy looked caught.

While his fingers and toes went cold, and his face drew down, sunken and chilled, he maintained protocol for the sake of Susan and Kimmy’s dad, saying now to his wife, “Did you want to come along?”

And before his eyes, he could see color rising to the surface of his wife’s freckled cheeks. What had she been texting? She said, “Come along where?” Her voice was thin and quiet.

Then Simon joined them, shrugging on his light cotton jacket to go down to the chilly underground parking. Pop said to his daughter, “See your new car.”

“Oh, yeah, the new car.” Kimmy shut off her phone and put it facedown in her lap. “Yeah, okay.”

Susan was there, standing close to Simon. She said to Kimmy: “You like it? It’s good?”

“It’s comfortable,” she said.

Simon said to Josh, “It has good tires? You know, for the snow? . . .”

He said, “They threw snows in, and they keep them for her at the dealership.”

“Oh, that’s good,” Simon said, nodding, then nodding to Kimmy.

“I know,” she said. “I know. No, I love it. We had a great drive up here.” She ran hair from her face. She still looked flushed.

“Are you coming down with us?” He regretted the natural coldness in his tone.

Their gazes connected, and he saw trouble in her eyes—but then she shot him a puzzled look, recovering now from being caught, turning the tables on him, acting like she wondered what was wrong with him. She said to her dad: “Yeah, I’ll come down. I didn’t even get to eat my cake . . .”

Simon said, “Not wait for you all day. Kids and their phones . . .”

She said, “Pop, you said I could . . .”

“Didn’t say we would wait,” Simon said, playing at indifference as he headed to the door.

Kimmy said after him: “But could I . . .”

Susan smiled, joining Simon walking toward the door. “Come on, Kimmy, come on,” Simon said without looking back, “come take us for a ride . . .”

“Okay,” she said, “I’ll come along in a minute, you guys go without me.”

Josh said to her, “What’s going on?”

“Work stuff.”

“Are you coming down or not?”

“I’ll come down—just give me a minute.”

“A minute for what?”

She whispered: “The bathroom, Josh—what’s wrong?”

“Nothing’s wrong, Kimmy.”

“You’re mad at me because I’m texting?”

He grunted. It was obvious. “Yeah, I’m mad at you because you’re texting.”

“I have to. It’s work.”

“We’re at your dad’s—we’re having lunch . . .”

“I have to take it. It’s my first week.” Now she rose, still pressing the screen of her phone facedown against her thigh. “You guys go without me, I’ll just be a couple minutes. I just have to go to the bathroom first, okay?”

“Fine,” he said, “meet us downstairs—out front of the lobby.”



On the lip of her father’s bathtub, phone propped against a full toilet roll placed in the center of the closed toilet seat, she slid her hand down her unzipped shorts. She’d waited until she heard the apartment door close, and now here she was in her father’s bathroom like she was fifteen again.

Contact with Devlin was finished. Her arrogant boss would be engaged with his buddies, another bunch of suit wearing assholes, she was sure,

drinking Scotch and getting hyped at the start of the baseball game, all of them with the best seats the Rogers Centre offered. Meanwhile, Devlin Stone's newest acquisition was jacking off in her dad's bathroom like it was high school. That's what she'd been reduced to.

As her fingers slipped up and down her hot and wet folds, parting flesh, caressing back her hood and dabbing at her clitoris, she recalled the object of her obsession lit up on her phone's screen a foot away from her.

The photo of Devlin naked, displaying for her that huge gorgeous cock.

Half hard in the photo, it was fully hard in her mind's eye. Her fingers swirling, whipping pleasure through herself, recalling it in the cargo container. The feel of it in her mouth. The distinct plump shape of his large cock head; when it was wet, poised as if it would enter her, she squirted, was overflowing with wet and telling him to put it in her even though he didn't wear a condom. The pills were probably already working (she'd lied to herself).

Devlin inspired risky—oh-so-risky—lust.

Now she was thinking of herself on the grass, closing her eyes, recalling that nighttime dark when she hated Devlin and wanted to hit him and he'd laid her back, got on top of her, and she opened her legs. He grabbed her there, between her legs, grabbed the crotch of her denim shorts, growled feeling the hot wetness through the fabric, took his hard cock out, laid it against the inside of her leg. . . . Both of them had worked while wrestling, trying to get his cock inside her without taking her pants off. How hot that had been. How awful. Caught then, and still not deterred, they'd ended up in the bathroom together where Karina thought they were 'working it out.' The only thing they were working out was his mouth on her neck, and her taking her shorts down. Karina was there again, persistent, knocking on the door, as Devlin was just about to put it inside her.

She hadn't even been drinking . . .

Now she was on her toes, bare feet on her dad's bathmat, clicking wet sounds from between her legs, thinking what it was finally like to have him

inside her—it didn't count as sex—letting her know just the kind of domination a man like . . .

“Oh wow, oh wow,” she panted, eyes open again, scanning, searching, finding the upturned photo on her phone, the one Devlin had sent of his naked body.

She came, one hand in her underwear, the other hand over her mouth, eyes focused hard on the man she would cheat on her husband with. Only once, just once.

If only masturbating could have solved this. If only having him inside her one time would've quenched her thirst . . . If only the condom-covered Magnum-sized cucumber had done the trick. But nothing was chilling her fever. So do it. Do it and be done.

It was supposed to be already done. Technically, as far as her relationship with Josh was concerned, her having sex with Devlin could have transpired that last year of high school when she wasn't even dating Josh. When she'd come back from Taiwan after she and Josh'd kissed, whatever it been between her and Josh had been laminated over . . . All their emotions that had bubbled to the surface stilled underneath a thin milky film. She still had feelings for him then, and maybe he still had feelings for her—but there was an unsureness. And neither of them'd pushed it.

And it was in that window of time when the first opportunity with Devlin came . . .

She clapped her thighs shut on her hand, trying to stop her own swirling finger from driving too much pleasure and making her cry out past her cupped hand. The hidden fear that if she moaned in orgasm, then stepped outside the bathroom, she'd find Susan had hung back to wait for her. Susan then knowing that her boyfriend's daughter jerked off in the bathroom during a family lunch.

She sat for a minute until she calmed, and her breath returned to normal. She dried between her legs with toilet paper, straightened her underwear,

flushed. Retrieved her phone, washed her hands with lots of soap and hot water, and hustled out to meet Josh . . .



At last, movement behind the reflection on the condo lobby glass windows. A figure approaching, height and thinness of his wife.

He was in the front seat of her new Nissan Leaf, air conditioning on, Pop in the passenger seat, Susan in the back. Making small talk for almost fifteen minutes now. If someone had to go to the bathroom, and it was going to be a number two that would take a while, it would've been nice to get a heads up.

He had the distinct feeling she'd pushed him off so she could keep texting with Devlin. I'll catch up. Yeah, right, he leaves with her dad and Susan, she's right back to texting again with Devlin. Doing that thing with her necklace in her mouth, smiling at her phone, smiling at Devlin's words, being flirty. It was an awful feeling.

All the impending sexual dread that he for some reason enjoyed up till this point was squashed now, seeing that hidden exchange between his wife and Devlin. Sure, he could be wrong. Maybe it was Tami. But it fucking wasn't Tami.

Kimmy was acting flirty like that while texting Devlin Stone. The worst guy in his life. So, no. This couldn't go on.

As the door swung open and Kimmy hustled out to join them—dressed in her pleated shorts, striding long bare legs, feet in her shiny loafers—he got out to greet her. Over the top of her new Leaf, he gave her an expression to let her know how he felt being made to wait so long. He snipped, “You all finished now?”

It faltered her, and her quick steps slowed. He held open the driver door for her, letting her drive so he could get in the back.

“Josh, I had to go to the bathroom,” she said in a low whisper as he got close.

“Great,” he said, “let’s get going, okay?—show them your car . . .”

Kimmy’s face flashed sadness, then mild disappointment. But most importantly: guilt. Maybe she would finally get the message. Smarten up.

He’d distinctly told her the kind of guy Devlin could be, and she disregarded him. Disregarded him and then let things get worse. He kept her eye as he backed to the rear door, opened it, threw himself in to sit next to Susan. Forced a smile on his face.

V

Sunday, August 9

Overheard

There were better ways for him to spend his evening, but this is the way it was. A lone man on his horse, wandering the digital mountainside, aimless, staring at pixel scenery. He was in the living room playing Red Dead, Kimmy alone in her Katt Basket room, mid-process of turning it into an office. They could have split the office space he already used, but Kimmy apparently wanted privacy. That room had been her basket workspace, and baskets could not have been prepared in his office because basket-making demanded too much space. They couldn't share an office? And here's the thing: The basket room had at one time been destined a nursery . . .

Out of nowhere, this thing with him and Kimmy and Devlin had jumped right off the track and now rusty wheels squealed against rusty track, sparks flew, and there was a chance the whole thing would upend and his mining cart loaded with precious ore would dash below. It was funny how fast things changed—even when you did your best to make them as smooth as they could be.

So even though there were better ways to spend an evening, here was where he found himself, looking to escape.



Five o'clock in Ajax was nine o'clock in England. At her desk, office door half-closed, she listened to the phone ring. Amy picked up, saying, "Why

haven't you called?"

"I'm calling now."

"I mean, I get the not texting, not wanting anything in writing, but Kimmy . . ."

She said again: "I'm calling now."

Amy'd sent over two dozen messages in the last weeks and Kimmy'd replied with Talk Later, but never actually talked later. Until now. And Amy was right: she didn't want to commit anything to where it could be read by unwelcome eyes. But what was the point now? She'd committed a worse sin than messaging with a friend about cheating on her husband, she had full-on sexting with her boss, including requesting and receiving an official Big Dick Pic. And making plans for what could be the real deal. The real Point of No return committed to readable text. Thusly, she called Amy. A bad influence, but a somehow welcome one.

Amy said, "Well, I hope you're glad—you've got me on the edge of my seat. What the hell's been happening?"

"Where do I start?" Kimmy rubbed her forehead, wincing, wanting to get into it, but also knowing the magnitude of this story. Amy told her to start at the beginning, so that's what she did: telling Amy how the job came to pass and how crazy she was to work for Devlin.

It was quiet a moment, and then Amy said, "You're going to sleep with him."

"No, I'm not." She hated the restrained but still apparent exuberance in her old friend's voice.

"Kimmy, what you did in your hallway . . .?"

"That's not . . ." But it was futile. With resignation, she said, "I know."

Amy made an exasperated sound, said, "Why couldn't this be while I was still in Toronto?"

“It’s your fault,” she said. Though it wasn’t.

Amy disregarded her, saying with disbelief: “And Josh knows you’re working for Devlin?”

“Of course he does.”

“Don’t know what that says about him,” Amy said aside from her phone.

“Josh knows it’s a good opportunity.”

“I’m sure he does. How’s that been going?”

“With Josh? We’ve barely said a word today.”

“What’s going on?”

She swiveled her chair toward the door, saw the hall empty, said, “It’s getting to him. Me talking about Devlin.”

“Does he suspect anything?”

“No. I don’t think he does.”

“And nothing’s happened since your apartment?”

“With Devlin. No. Well, yeah.”

“Yeah, what?”

“Just . . . more of the same.”

Amy chuckled, the chuckle becoming an anxious groan. “Fuck, he’s so hot.” She said it in a tight, desperate way, and she could imagine Amy scratching at her own throat, reminiscing of her few times with Devlin. But what was she going to say—was she going to agree with Amy? As much as she wanted to be on the same page as Amy, it still felt so wrong to be a married woman lusting after another man.

But then why did you want to talk to Amy in the first place—the day before you were having drinks after work with Devlin . . . in a hotel bar?

“He is,” she agreed in a quiet whisper. Then: “I don’t think it’s going to happen.” Why would she call Amy if all she was going to do was lie to her? “I couldn’t do that to Josh . . .”



Couldn’t do what to Josh?

Outside the hall bathroom, he paused, hand on the lever and now trying to eavesdrop on his wife. Kimmy was talking to Amy. Didn’t hear Kimmy’s phone ring, but that didn’t mean Amy didn’t call. He was operating under the pretense Kimmy’d called Amy. Why would Kimmy want to call Amy?

He and Kimmy’d spent the day apart and mostly quiet, though they weren’t fighting. Avoiding each other, that was what they were doing. Not wanting to get into it.

It was hard to hear his wife over the pounding of his heart. As soon as he’d detected Kimmy was talking in hushed tones, and then hearing her utter his name, his pulse was racing out of control. His palm sweated so fast his grip on the bathroom door lever slackened and slipped. He wiped his hand on his stomach, still trying to listen in to Kimmy’s conversation with Amy.

For almost a minute, Kimmy spoke so quietly into her phone he couldn’t make out what she said. Just the soft sibilance of her S sounds. While he didn’t want to be that kind of guy, he knew he was that kind of guy—and now he was crossing on tiptoes the four extra steps to make it to the doorway.

Kimmy still spoke low, but he could make out her end of the conversation, Kimmy saying to Amy now: “No, not like that . . . just one other time . . .

Yeah . . . Tell me about it . . . No, I can't believe it, it's so . . . right . . . Just hands . . . Hands and, you know, mouth . . .”

Hands and mouth?

It didn't take much imagination for his dirty mind to figure what was being said. If that's what she was saying. In his twisted version, Kimmy was telling Amy how she'd been doing hands and mouth stuff with Devlin. He put a fist over his sternum, pressed it hard. Forced himself to breathe low and quiet, and strained to listen.

“Yeah, no, you're not kidding . . . Was it like that? . . . Yeah . . . No, but . . . uh-huh . . . But you never . . . Is it ever a lot?”

Is what a lot?

“Stop laughing . . . I'm serious . . . Like what? . . . Yeah, like that . . . Well, not like that . . . A little like that . . . Yeah, down my legs . . . I don't think it's funny . . .”

What was down her legs? Her skirt? Her panties? What wasn't funny?

Kimmy asked Amy: “That's never happened to you?”

A long pause.

“Very funny . . . Just me then . . . Why do I tell you anything?”

Kimmy's chair squeaked, and his heart completely stopped beating. He went statuesque, stuck with his back against the wall, knowing Kimmy had just got up from her office chair. She was coming out here. Coming out to the hall. Going to continue her conversation with Amy in the kitchen, maybe put on a kettle . . .

Now he loosened, tried to stand casual like he wasn't eavesdropping, just walking down the hall, even posing now mid-stride so when she came around the corner he would pretend to stop short so they wouldn't collide. Say: “Ho, whoa, hey, sorry,” put his hands on her shoulders, sidestepping, then head on into the bedroom.

Her shadow came near the door, and those missed heartbeats came back now all at once. Just a sudden drum solo in his chest. Vision warbling and shaking—and how the hell was he going to pretend nothing was going on when his cheeks were probably blazing red right now . . .?

He chickened out, put himself back up against the wall, not having the guts to put on the fake-act for her, preferring to be caught like the dirty sneak he was . . .

Kimmy appeared in the doorway, just her shoulder, not her face at all. But he could tell she held the phone to her cheek and was looking down the hall from where he came. Shoot, if he'd been standing in the hall posed mid-stride, she would've spotted him—but now she didn't. She stepped back and closed the door.

Every urge he had to go to the kitchen, grab a drinking glass, return and put it up to the door as a crude listening device were forced away. He couldn't be like that. What had he done to himself right now? Potentially embarrassed himself bottomlessly. What would it have looked like her finding him eavesdropping on her phone conversation? Yeah, the guy that got bullied, and now he was sneaking around trying to listen in on the things she said to her friends. Not a good look. Not a good look when she went to work every day for Devlin Stone in his expensive car, his expensive clothes, tall and good-looking . . .

He rubbed his cheeks, went on the pads of his feet softly to the bathroom and closed himself in. But he couldn't pee now. Just like that night at Tiffany's, it'd be hard to pee when his dick was thundering upright.

He palmed his erection, rubbed his hand in a circle over it and getting some pleasure. Didn't make sense to be hard listening to your wife maybe talk about using her hands and her mouth on Devlin Stone. But for whatever reason, as much as that hurt him deep, his body responded in an unexpected way.

“Shit,” he said, turning and sitting on the toilet seat.

He'd have to wait out the erection. He unzipped it, pulled it out, thought about jerking off and getting rid of it that way . . . Then hated the idea of sitting in the bathroom by himself in a fight with Kimmy, her talking to Amy, him imagining their conversation was about Devlin, then doing that? . . . Jerking off to that?

What if he told her more?

What if you took the honesty thing a little more seriously, Josh? What if you told her just a little bit more . . .

Tell

Josh was sitting on the couch where she'd last seen him, only now the TV was off. So he was sitting by himself, facing the television, the room dead quiet. If he wasn't so upright, she would've thought he'd drifted off and the sleep timer had shut the equipment down. Sunlight came in the window still, lighting up the room, but with her husband in there and everything else so inactive, the room seemed dim.

She slowed, pausing at the kitchen pass-through. "Josh?"

His head turned, and she regarded his profile. Noted his somber expression.

She said, "Everything okay?"

He nodded. Still not saying anything.

"You just sitting here?"

Now he turned around, putting his elbow over the back of the couch and showing her his face. He said, "Can you come sit with me and talk?"

Whoosh. It was like her mental toilet had just been flushed. Everything shot down her plumbing, into the basement, her feet instantly going cold and feeling fat and swollen. Her heart thudded, her cheeks burned. She said, "Uh-huh, yeah," then turned aside like she was looking for some sort of escape hatch. She said, "Can you let me get a drink of water first?"

Josh nodded. She crept behind his back, went into the kitchen, ran the faucet and brought down a drinking glass. Both hands on the sink lip, she crumpled against the counter. Oh shoot, shoot, shoot, shoot, oh my God, oh

my freaking God. He knows! Oh my God, he freaking knows! . . . Stomach cinched to a hard rubber ball, her eyes swelled with tears. What did he know? How did he find out? Did he see the picture? Holy freaking shit, did he see the picture of Devlin on her phone? . . . “God, fuck, no,” she whispered, ran her glass under the faucet stream and filled it. Shut the lever closed, snatched paper towels from a roll and dried her face. Sniffled, blew her nose. Knocked back her water and wiped her mouth. Oh God dammit, poor Josh. Oh God, how could she do any of this to him?

Now she walked around the couch, cursing herself for her accidental timid wife pose. Fingers interlinked, hands held at her waist: the submissive woman. Coming around the couch now, hoping he wouldn’t see the puffiness of her eyes, could tell that she was crying. . . . She sat down next to him. “What do you want to talk about?”

And her husband just sat there. The two of them in their Sunday sweats, alone in their apartment, a beautiful sunny day outside the window. Not talking to each other. Slinking around the house and avoiding each other. Him mad at her for texting. Her mad at him for being mad at her for texting. It was work, Josh. It was work. Mad at him like it really was for work. But it wasn’t. Did he know that now? Where did she leave her phone that he saw it?

Seeing his morose face, his sunken eyes and sloping shoulders had her wanting to instantly cuddle him. Comfort him for the harm she’d done. Try to explain it all away—though there was no explanation. And if she put her arms out right now and held him, and he screamed at her, a hair trigger being set off with her touch, shouting, throwing things, being mad enough to strike her . . . Could he do that? Josh would never do that. Josh would never do it, but look at all she’d done to him. She left him with nowhere else to go. Had broken his heart. So while she wanted to comfort this man she loved, she sat there with her hands gathered in her lap and waited to hear what it was that he’d found out.

Josh was taking his time, preparing himself, letting her know that this was going to be a doozy. She said, “Tell me.”

It broke the spell, and though he still wouldn't look at her, his eyes opened wider, staring out the window, sunlight making the wet on his pupils shimmer. He said, "I told you about Devlin . . ."

"I know. I know he was a bully."

"He was," he said and rolled his eyes.

"No," she said, "I know. You told me . . ."

"I don't know how to say this . . ."

Oh fuck, here it came. Somehow, Josh knew. Someone had told on her. Oh crap—the party. Tiffany's party. On Facebook, maybe? There was chatter online now about what she'd done. Surprised there hadn't been already. . . . But that's what it was. People talking about the rumors of what Karina and Amy saw. Her and Devlin. But dammit, she'd fixed that, hadn't she? Admitted to being pinned on the ground underneath Devlin. Admitted to Devlin trying to kiss her. Everything involving that night had been cut and stacked in a barrier of plausible deniability. Oh, they're exaggerating, Josh. Rumors. Just ask Amy. Shit, don't ask Karina. God, don't ask Karina . . .

He said, "Remember that night when we came back from the Dragon?"

"Yeah." She wanted to put her hand on him again. Rest her palm on her husband's bare forearm. But she waited. Would wait till it was okay . . .

"You told me what happened at the party."

What had he read? What were people saying about her?

"When we came back"—now he turned in his seat and thumbed toward their foyer—"remember the card? . . ."

"Right. The business card . . ."

"I told you I found it."

And here she was, pulling her hand back again. Wanting to touch him, but afraid.

“I didn’t find it, Kimmy.”

“What do you mean?”

“I didn’t find it. Devlin told me it was there.”

Now she frowned. Frowned because that didn’t make sense. And what had she told Josh about that?

He said, “Devlin told me it was there. I didn’t find it on my own.”

“What do you mean Devlin told you?”

“He told me he put it there.”

Now all that cotton fuzzy dread got pushed away by her pounding adrenaline-spiked heartbeat. “Devlin told you that? When were you talking to Devlin?”

He paused a long moment, still not able to look at her. “He texted me. Told me to look in the drawer. He said he put it there . . . left it there for me.”

Now she was stuck in her own storyline. Walking the path of her lie, afraid to walk deeper into the lie’s darkening forest, worried because she wasn’t sure she was leaving a good enough trail behind her if she needed to find her way out again. But she ventured forth: “I put it there, Josh.”

“Yeah,” he said. “You told me that . . .”

He didn’t believe her? Well, she didn’t put it there. But how else would it get there? “What do you mean he texted you?”

“On my phone, Kimmy, how else?”

“How did he get your phone number?”

Josh shrugged. Couldn't come up with an answer.

"What did he say?" She chewed her cheek.

Josh vacillated like there was only so much of this he wanted to tell her. And now, as much as she hated it, she feared this could be a ruse on her husband's part. He was testing her honesty. Testing her resolve to the story of Devlin's business card's provenance. Only why? Because he was scared . . .

Josh said, "He said he came by. He said he was in our apartment."

Whoosh again. Toilet flushing. Cold feet, hot face. "I told you he wasn't here," she said, and though she'd meant it louder, it came out as a whisper. Proof she was lying.

"That's not what he told me."

She said, "Would you look at me, please? Stop looking away. I want to look in your eyes."

It took a while, but Josh turned his face to hers. Their eyes met, and she saw genuine hurt there. She said, "Show me the text. I want to see it."

Now their eyes disconnected, and she felt that momentary mistrust. There was no text.

And sure enough, Josh said now: "I deleted it."

"Why would you do that?"

"Because I believed you. I believed what you told me about the card, and I believed what you told me about the party."

Now she couldn't hold back any longer, reaching across the divide between them—that six-inch couch space—and rested her hand on his arm. He didn't explode in rage. Didn't shout at her, jump back, or whip his arm away. He looked soothed by her touch, and that meant an incredible amount

to her. She stroked his arm hairs with her thumb. “You threw it out because you believe me?”

“I spent an awful lot of time in high school and elementary school with that guy in my head, Kimmy. I’m an adult now. I’m married. I’ve got a great job. I’m not that kid anymore. I’m not his puppet. I’m not his toy. I asked you; you told me the truth. You tell me the truth. All he does is lie and manipulate. This text from him was like a thorn stuck in me. You know? Embedded, leaking poison. So I flicked it away. It doesn’t exist anymore.”

“Can you get it back?”

He shook his head no.

“That’s all it said? That he’d left you his business card?”

Josh’s face went grim again. Vacillating. Like there was more that had been texted, but he didn’t want to deal with it. At last, he nodded. “Yeah, he just texted me to let me know he’d left me a gift.”

“Any idea why he would do that though?”

He scoffed like the answer was obvious. “To fuck with me, Kimmy.”

She frowned again, but showed him a supportive expression. “You said it yourself. You’re an adult now, he’s an adult too. Why would he bother with something like that?” Was it possible? Did Devlin do that? There was the Devlin that Josh described. There was the Devlin she remembered. And there was the Devlin she knew now. All dark gradations. All shades of a dominant and mean personality. But the Devlin from high school was not Devlin the man. Would Devlin really send such a ridiculous text? To set her husband up? Was this wounds percolating up from Josh’s past? Josh afraid the current status of his wife texting her boss while at lunch with her family?—it was something Josh was mad about—and fearful Josh, bullied Josh, concocting this scenario was meant to deter her from close contact with a man he hated. The story Josh told her was benign enough. Benign and unprovable. Devlin texted him to say the business card was in the drawer. So what? Yes, Devlin had been here that day. He’d been here that

day and had done terrible things to her in the hallway. But would he leave his card afterward, then text Josh to taunt him? It sounded like something out of a high school movie. Was Devlin stuck in high school? No. Was Josh?

She said, “I wish you could show me. I know his text number.”

He looked her way. “You do.”

“I do.”

Now Josh frowned. “So . . . you don’t think it was him?”

“Could somebody be playing a joke on you?”

Defensive, Josh reeled and pulled his arm from her touch. “Who would do that? What’s funny about that?”

“I don’t know, Josh,” she said. “I’m not defending Devlin, I just wish you could show me the text.”

“Well, I can’t, okay? I told you it was poison. I got rid of it. I just want you to know the kind of man you’re working for.”

“Josh, don’t attack me. I’m under no illusion what kind of person Devlin is. What kind of man he is.”

For some reason, that wounded Josh. He reeled again. “Don’t call him that.”

“Call him what? A man?”

“It shows him respect.”

“I don’t respect him, Josh—he’s just my boss. I don’t know what you want from me . . .” Wow . . . now she saw something more clearly, saying: “I mean, if this is true about the text then—”

“What—it isn’t true? You think I’m lying?” He stood up and crossed his arms.

She put her hands up defensively saying, “No-no, I know, I’m not saying you’re lying, I’m saying this text that you’re telling me about came in before the job offer. We sat, and we talked, right here—” now she patted the couch where he’d just been sitting—“here, Josh, we sat here and talked about what it would mean. You didn’t tell me about the text. Why wouldn’t you bring that up? Like, if you would told me that, Josh, it would’ve changed my mind totally. And if you’d showed me the text . . .?”

“You don’t believe he sent it?” His voice was raised.

“I believe he sent it,” she said—though she didn’t. “Don’t be mad. I’m just telling you you never brought it up. You’re sitting here telling me how hurt you are by all of that, and yet when you had the chance, you didn’t say anything? I already told immigration I’m not coming back. Now I’m working at Stone. . . . Did you want me to quit Stone? Because if you want me to quit, this just seems like an enormous waste of time. For both of us . . .”

“I should’ve told you.”

“See? Can you see what I’m saying?”

He nodded, arms crossed tighter. But with his arms crossed there was something undeniable: Josh had an erection. She ignored his bulge; he was standing above her with his crotch near her face, scowling across the room. She said again, “Look at me, Josh.”

And again, taking forever to meet her eyes, he finally obeyed. “What? . . .”

She said, “I’m sorry. I just wanted to know if the text was real or not because I’m in a tough situation now. If you’re telling me this is real, then I shouldn’t be working for him. But you never told me when you should have. You’re telling me now. I have to weigh how serious you took it at the time. You didn’t take it serious enough at the time to tell me . . . What does that mean?”

Despite her pleasant and calm tone, Josh’s scowl deepened. “You’re such a fucking lawyer,” he said, waved a backhand at her like she was nothing and

walked away.

“Josh, don’t leave me here, don’t do that . . .”

But now he was mad, walking quick, heading out of the living room and down the hall to the bedroom.

Upper Hand

Ten minutes on the bed waiting for her to join him, and she didn't. Sitting with his butt on the pillows, one leg folded underneath him, the other bare foot dangling off the bed's edge. How had he fucked that up so bad? Everything he said was right. She didn't believe him? Yeah, she had good points . . .

As soon as she presented those good points, you sure turned tail and ran . . .

That was true.

This was just so fucking ridiculous. Why'd he not tell her there was more detail in the text? Tell her about Devlin's taunts about fingering his wife in their front hall. How the guy described their front hall, though he was supposed to have never been here . . .

Too scared to do that. Too scared to put in his wife's head the image of her being fingered by Devlin. Worried it might cause her some psychic trauma since she'd been pinned down and dry humped by the guy, but also worried Kimmy would hear that and think it was arousing. Which was stupid. Or maybe it wasn't. Who knew?

How was he supposed to deal with this? You could tell her all the truth. Tell her everything that was in the text. Tell her how you live texted with him. Tell her about how he taunted you in the tent. If that was real.

Fucking fuck. Why had he ever let her start there at Stone's?—because Kimmy was right: she quit immigration. Quit them after a long maternity leave, which put her in a bad spot to return. They wouldn't take her back. Who would trust her now? Especially if they wanted kids again. And for

fuck sakes, they did want kids. What better way to have kids than for her to work for Stone Brokerage for a couple of years building up a fat nest egg while he built up his resume at Swanson. There was lots of upward mobility at Swanson. And he would fill it. Three years down the road, it wasn't crazy to think he could be VP. Wasn't crazy at all. More responsibility, but probably an extra 40-grand. If they kept living the way they lived, put that extra money aside . . .? Shit, that money that Kimmy was making? . . .

Now he wanted to take the nearest pillow and either fling it across the room or lay back in the bed and smother himself until his legs stopped kicking. End this suffering.

The bedroom door opened. Kimmy coming in. Looking like adorable college Kimmy. Wearing her faded Queens hoodie, a pair of cotton shorts just high enough so he couldn't not think about sex.

And that's where this erection came from. Not thinking about that text and not thinking about Devlin taunting about how he'd fingered his wife in the front hall and how his wife had lied about it. Because that was impossible. That was impossible—and look at her. Who wouldn't get an erection looking at her like this?

Before she'd even closed the door behind her, he was apologizing. "I'm sorry, Kimmy . . ."

She slumped, turned and leaned her back against the closed door. "I'm sorry, Josh. I don't know how things got so messed up."

"Would you come here?" he asked and held out his hand.

Wow—feel that heartbeat when his familiar good buddy, wife and lover smiled and trotted the distance to the bed?

She climbed up from the foot of the bed on hands and knees to join him in the pillows. They sat side-by-side, both of their heads turned to the left and looking at the summery blue sky. "Not the best weekend," he said, "such a nice day out there, we could've done better things."

“Nope,” she said. “We had to mope around the house today.”

“I was mad. Mad about you texting.”

“You should be. And I’m sorry. But you know that I had to, right?”

He didn’t want to fight about it. He could present arguments, but it was better to say: “I know.”

Kimmy’s wrist bumped against his thigh, her hand seeking out his. He turned his palm up, and they wove fingers. He hoisted her hand up to his mouth and kissed her knuckles right below her wedding ring. She leaned against him and said, “We can’t fight, Josh.”

“I know we can’t.”

“We have to talk. If something like that ever happens again, you have to tell me. When it’s time to talk, we have to be honest. I need to be honest, too . . .”

“I used to think we were good communicators.”

“We are,” she said. “But maybe it’s not always easy . . .”

“No. Not always.” Whatever happened between her and Devlin had made things difficult. And now with him and his past with Devlin, things were made even more difficult. How on earth did he ever think it was a good idea to let her go to work for that guy? It would have been better to never let it happen. Devlin was the common denominator in all their troubles.

Kimmy still sat shoulder-to-shoulder but pivoted, resting her cheek on his chest, curling up against him. She said, “The day’s not totally ruined.”

“What do you want to do?”

“Let’s go out to dinner. Let’s go and get crazy. All-you-can-eat. Maybe we’ll even have some drinks . . .”

“I like it,” he said, a warm feeling washing through him.

Now she sat upright again, and he liked the smile on her face. God, all that tension before, and all he had to do was talk and look how it melted away. And when it melted away look at what beauty and grace you were left with: Kimmy lifted a knee, then hiked her leg up high and around his back, almost clocking him in the face with her ankle, both of them laughing, saying it was a good thing he ducked forward. And he caught a glimpse very high up the inside of her thighs—that inner tendon that ran right up to her crotch. It made his erection return to throbbing. “What are you doing?”

She squirted in behind him, long skinny legs folding across his lap now, wrapping her arms underneath his arms and hugging herself to his back. He could feel the point of her chin rubbing into his collar. Wow, feeling her arms around him felt incredible. Love burst from his heart, feeling this woman’s body clung to his back this way. She squeezed him tight until both of them were groaning. She said, “I love you so much, Josh.”

He caressed her hands over his chest saying, “I love you too, Kimmy. So, so much.”

They breathed against each other for a little while, his wife’s hands caressing his chest, until she started flicking at his nipple. She said, “We’re going to figure this out. Okay? It’s you and me, and we’re going to figure it out.”

“We will,” he said, “we’ll figure it out.”

Her other hand flicked his other nipple.

“Stop doing that,” he said, laughing.

“Are they sensitive?”

“A little,” he said, surprised by her playfulness.

She clutched her leg-lock tighter and hugged him. He leaned back, and her hands drifted down his stomach. He jolted, knowing what she would find—but hoping she would find it now. She did; her hand fell in his lap, and her palm rested over the hump of his erection. She said, “I thought so.”

“What do you mean you thought so?”

“I thought I saw something.”

“When?”

She patted his bulge. “Do you like fighting with me?”

“No. Not at all. Not even a little, Kimmy.”

“Are you sure about that?” she said, ran her warm hand up under his T-shirt then slipped it down the front of his sweat pants and underwear. Her nails grazed his hard shaft, then her fingers wrapped a tight O-ring around his scrotum, choking off his testicles. “You sure?”

He groaned, closed his eyes. “It’s seeing you in those shorts.”

“Are you looking at my legs?”

“I can’t help it,” he said.

She stretched her legs out now, putting her ankles over the points of his knees. She wore scratchy socks, and he hooked an index finger in each one and pulled them off. He rubbed his thumbs over the insoles of her pretty feet.

“That feels good,” she purred.

Now her grip found his shaft. She began to stroke him gently, up and down, going easy. She whispered near his ear, “Get your pants down.”

Hot dog. The whole day they were being terse with each other, he overhears some dumb conversation and imagines it being dirty, then confides in his wife, and then they fight . . . Look at this: now it had blown over and they were going to have sex.

She put her feet flat on the bed, and he lifted his butt and scooted his sweatpants down to mid-thigh. He sat in the V of her open legs again. She hooked her feet around and locked them in his lap, her left hand around his

chest, fingers tickling his armpit while her right hand began to slowly stroke him.

She said, “We’re going to figure this out, Josh. I love you more than anything. You know that, right?”

“I know,” he said.

“So if we love each other, we can get through this. We just need to talk.”

“Talk a little bit more.”

“Yes,” she said, laughing, bringing her hand up to her mouth and licking her fingers. When she returned her grip to his erection, it was slippery now. He jolted, then laughed.

“You’re so hard,” she said, “you get that hard just looking at my bare legs?”

“I do,” he said.

And now she really surprised him. She batted his erection with the back of her hand, making it bounce. “You’re a bad boy,” she said.

This sudden and weird action from his wife tightened a dark and lusty knot below his stomach. Couldn’t even believe she did it.

He said, “I am a bad boy.”

“Stop being so bad,” she said, slapping his erection with a backhand then a forehand. Going light and teasing, not trying to hurt him. But this was way dirtier than Kimmy had ever been. And he liked it.

“I can’t help myself,” he said, voice tight, feeling like this was a dream.

“We’ll have to do something with this thing, Josh,” she said, “we can’t have you going out for dinner with it poking out your pants now, can we?”

“No,” he said, “we can’t,” and ran his hand up the inside of her thigh, trying to get between her legs at the small of his back. She cinched her scissoring

legs on him tighter, saying, “Keep your hands to yourself.”

“Yes, ma’am,” he said, and laughed, still bewildered by the change in their day—so glad to have his Kimmy back.

She laughed, stroked him a little faster and then bit his neck. The feel of his wife’s teeth chomping on that sensitive spot where his neck met his shoulder got his nipples hard like a woman for some reason. “Ow, hey,” he laughed, and she hugged him tight, bit and kissed his neck and jerked his cock.

“Sheez, Kimmy,” he said, “wow . . .”

“You like that?” The voice was familiar but her tone strikingly dominant.

“I do,” he said, meaning it.

She whispered in his ear while she jerked wild pleasure on his slippery aching cock: “You’re going to come for me?”

“If you, ah, want me to . . .”

She whispered, “Is your cock my slave?”

He laughed at the outrageous words. “What . . .?”

He tried to turn to see how serious her face was, but she squeezed him tighter. “You think that’s funny?”

“Yeah,” he said.

And she stopped completely.

She hugged herself to his back, both her hands rubbing his chest and shoulders now.

He said, “What are you doing?”

“If you’re not going to take this serious . . .”

All the pleasure that had built near bursting in his belly expanded, washed his insides, seeking to find the release it was promised. It felt like his stomach had dropped away. “I’m taking it seriously,” he said.

“Beg me to continue.”

The urge to laugh again came on strong, but the mood she was in made it clear to him she wouldn’t play along. Her game was to be in control. And, fuck, it was wild and unexpected and so crazy exciting. His stomach raced with a high tickle all of a sudden, like he’d just crested a peak on a roller coaster hill and was heading down the fun side. “Please,” he said.

“It sounds like you’re still laughing.”

“I am,” he said, unable to help himself. “Sorry . . .”

“Okay,” she said, brightly—but disappointed—a tone letting him know this was his choice, “I’m going to hop in the shower and get ready. You want to go to that Brazilian place? That’s all-you-can-eat. I feel like having—”

“Okay-okay,” he said, stopping her, feeling like she would act out getting from behind him if he didn’t play along. Earnestly now, he said, “Please, Kimmy, please don’t stop.”

“That’s better,” she said, squeezing both his nipples before returning her right hand to his lap.

Her grip on him this time was like liquid—and she made an appreciative sound at the feel in her grip. “Wow, somebody really does want me to continue.” He’d spewed pre-come down his shaft while she paused to tease him.

Now he surrendered to her. His beautiful wife; his smart and loving girl clinging to him and delivering pleasure to him in a masterful way he never imagined his wife would ever do. He watched her feet; sometimes he would rub her insoles and play with her toes while she slowly jerked him off. When he would get close to orgasm, she would slow. And then he would thrust his cock through her loose grip but she would match his thrusts to

prevent him from having pleasure until he groaned a complaint. Then she would jerk him fast and he would gasp and almost collapse from pleasure. Never in their life together had Kimmy been so sexually forward and . . . capable.

Three times she brought him very close to orgasm and then squeezed his cock head and stopped. And she was rough at times, too. Spanking the belly of his erection, getting it to bounce. She even squeezed his testicles.

Now she was whispering again, “Are you going to come?—I can tell you’re going to come . . .”

“I am,” he croaked.

Then she suddenly and furiously jerked him hard and fast. And just when he thought it was going to happen, she stopped again. It frustrated him in wondrous ways.

It had been almost fifteen minutes of this, a quarter hour of incredible slow torturous pleasure. It was like he was with another woman. It was definitely Kimmy behind him, but this playfulness, this naughtiness, was not something he knew from her. If they could work this out together—no, they would work this out together—and it did this to their sex life, well, why would he ever not want her to work for Devlin Stone?

“Oh shit, oh shit, oh shit, Kimmy, oh shit . . .”

She stopped jerking, said, “What is it?” acting curious.

“Dammit,” he said, thrusting his fists onto the mattress on either side of his wife’s thighs.

She giggled and laughed, squirmed aside and looked in his lap.

“Come on,” he said, “come on . . . please do it now and don’t stop . . .” Meaning for her to continue, but instead she watched around his arm as his orgasm began to leak from him.

Two short and meager spurts bubbled from his urethra, and then semen began to roil then roll down his shaft.

“Oh no,” she lamented while watching his orgasm fail. Then: “Don’t get it on the bed, Josh . . .”

Disappointment flooded his heart, and his stomach hurt, and yet he wouldn’t take control of his own—

Kimmy grabbed his erection again and jerked him fast and bit his shoulder. The surprise pleasure was intense. Otherworldly. The soaring ecstasy from the depths of his ruined orgasm shot out of the stratosphere; its renewal had his heart pounding in his chest and his vision going pale.

“Oh my God, oh my God, oh shit,” he said, and though his semen only boiled over his wife’s knuckles, the pleasure and pressure inside his brain and his cock was like the launching of a rocket.

He grabbed bedding and pulled it, tore and twisted. Kimmy had wracked him with pleasure like he hadn’t had before. He never felt like such a victim under her sexuality. It had always been imaginary before. Subjugating himself to her sexuality in his own mind; a one-sided game. Recently, thinking of her with another man had done something weird to the dynamic with his wife, but now in this moment Kimmy was the one actually leveraging her sexuality over top of him. Not imaginary. A hundred percent for real. And wonderful.

“Oh Josh, that was crazy,” she said, hugging her cheek to his arm in a loving way. That momentarily dominant Kimmy washed away and his wife returned. “Look at this,” she said, holding out her hand. The whole back was glazed.

She moved it nearer his face, and in her current playful state he worried she’d touch the mess to his mouth or nose.

“Don’t,” he said laughing, trying to hold on to her arm. And if she hadn’t been planning on doing it before, now she was thinking about it.

“What’s the matter, Josh?” she said, trying to move it near his mouth.

“Don’t,” he laughed, taking her wrist. But she didn’t pursue it, just being cute with him, not wanting to mess his mouth.

They squirmed and wrestled together, got up on knees, then collapsing with both their heads at the foot of the bed. She held her dirty hand away from him, not threatening with it anymore. They were face-to-face, the sun behind his back lighting up her beautiful eyes. He cupped her jaw and thumbed her cheekbone.

She said, “I really do love you so much, Josh. More than anything . . .”

“I love you, too,” he said, moving closer until they kissed, heart pounding, wondering how he could ever doubt her.

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